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CONG TO EXPAND ITS OUTREACH TO STUDENTS, TEMPLE TRUST PROTESTS

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NEW DELHI: The Congress Working Committee (CWC) said on Wednesday it would double down on the party's outreach to students by extending Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi's "Chhatron ki Goonj" programme to 800 towns, launch a grassroots agitation against alleged donation theft at the Ram Mandir and resolved not to sing the full version of the national song Vande Mataram at party events.

Party chief Mallikarjun Kharge asked Congress-led state governments to consult experts to prepare a blueprint for education and exam reforms in their respective states. →P6

NCERT REVAMPS CLASS 11 AND 12 POLITICAL SCIENCE TEXTBOOK PANEL

Press Trust of India

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NEW DELHI: The NCERT has reconstituted the Textbook Development Team for class 11 and 12 political science with a mandate to integrate cultural rootedness, Indian knowledge systems and inclusion, with at least four of the members having direct or indirect links with the RSS.

The team has been asked to develop the class 11 textbook by November and the class 12 book by July next year.

The textbook team will be led by academic and political analyst Sandeep Shastri, vice president of Karnataka-based deemed university NITTE. →P6

SC asks NTA where things stand on '24 exam reforms plan

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday asked the Union government to present details of its implementation of the recommendations of the K Radhakrishnan committee, constituted in the aftermath of the NEET-UG 2024 controversy, along with a definite timeline, stressing that it was more concerned with institutionalising the National Testing Agency (NTA) than merely putting in place security protocols on paper.

A bench of justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe, hearing petitions related to the NEET UG 2026 paper leak, directed the Union government to file an affidavit detailing the steps taken to implement the Radhakrishnan committee's recommendations, as "reflected and nuanced" by the high-powered task force headed by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani, and give indicative timelines for their implementation.

As part of its efforts to address the 2026 paper leak, the Union government set up a committee headed by Nilekani to address systemic issues; it has also sought to strengthen NTA, by creating new senior level positions, including for security. The Radhakrishnan committee was set up in the wake of a similar controversy two years ago, and

continued on →7

Implementation in progress

2 years after NEET leak panel was formed, key fixes remain

WHAT'S BEEN DONE

- NTA restructuring — domain-specific leadership, psychometric expertise (rolled out this year, after protests)
- 16 new permanent posts advertised at NTA; specialist hires in cybersecurity, digital forensics, assessment research and test-centre operations
- Strengthened frisking and repeat biometric verification after bio-breaks, tighter candidate verification

ANNOUNCED BUT NOT ROLLED OUT

- Multi-session testing for large examinations
- Multi-stage format for NEET-UG
- Shift of NEET-UG to a computer-based, multi-session format

WHAT HASN'T BEEN DONE

- DIGI-EXAM identity verification system
- Hybrid, computer-assisted secure question-paper transmission
- Collaborations with global testing agencies

The core recommendation that NTA stop conducting recruitment tests and focus on entrance exams has not been implemented. 21 of the panel's 41 long-term structural reforms remain untouched, an HT analysis found.

J'KHAND: 26-DAY STIR CALLED OFF AFTER EXAMS CANCELLED

The 26-day stir over alleged irregularities in Jharkhand's recruitment exams was suspended on Wednesday, with protesters giving the Hemant Soren government two months to address their grievances, even as those fearing job loss over exam cancellations moved the high court. The decision was announced by the student representatives, who called the move "a strategic pause" to see if the government fulfils its promises and warned of protesting again if it falls short. →P6

NTA TIGHTENS NORMS TO HIRE EXPERTS

Teachers who want to serve as subject experts for examinations conducted by NTA will have to submit multiple documents, including employment records and a no-objection certificate from their current employer. →P6

COURT SEEKS DETAILS OF NILEKANI TASK FORCE'S MANDATE

The Supreme Court bench hearing the NEET paper leak case sought clarity on the role of the Nandan Nilekani-led task force, which was constituted last month to overhaul India's exam system. →P6

IRAN WARNS GULF STATES AFTER UAE SNAPS TRADE TIES

TEHRAN: Iran's armed forces warned Gulf countries against assisting the US military on Wednesday, hours after the UAE announced it was severing economic ties with Tehran following new attacks on shipping. Iranian armed forces chief of staff Ali Abdollahi, according to the state-affiliated Mehr news agency, warned "any assistance or facilitation provided to the aggressor US military amounts to participation in the US military operation". →P9

MAHA DRAFT S.I.R ROLL DEFERRED TILL AUGUST 31

MUMBAI: The Election Commission of India (ECI) has deferred the publication of the draft electoral roll for Maharashtra by a week, from August 24 to August 31. The enumeration phase of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) ended on August 17. Electors left out from the roll can submit their objections between August 31 and September 30. The final roll will be published on November 11. →P5

MINISTERS TOLD TO SCALE UP SOCIAL MEDIA OUTREACH

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NEW DELHI: Members of the Union Council of Ministers received an analysis of their engagement on social media during Wednesday's cabinet meeting chaired by PM Narendra Modi and were also given instructions to scale up outreach, said people aware of the matter. →P6

Five Bangladeshis among nine dead in Kolkata hotel blaze

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KOLKATA: Five Bangladeshis, including a three-year-old boy, were among nine people killed after a fire broke out at a hotel on the second floor of a five-storey building on Mirza Ghalib Street in central Kolkata on Wednesday, officials said.

The blaze broke out around 2am at Shikha Inn, one of several small hotels operating from the building at 15H Mirza Ghalib Street. Officials suspect a short circuit triggered the fire.

Police and fire officials said the building housed multiple hotels and guest houses with small rooms and inadequate fire-safety arrangements. "The rooms in these hotels were small and most of them didn't have any window or ventilation. There was hardly any fire-alarm or fire-fighting system," state fire and emergency services minister Kaushik Chowdhury said. CM Suvenud Adhikari said a five-member special investigation team (SIT) has been formed to probe the fire and alleged lapses in fire-safety measures. →P7



Fire service personnel at the site of the fire in Kolkata on Wednesday. SAMIR JANA/HT PHOTO

Plan to redevelop 22 BEST depots cleared in BMC

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MUMBAI: A proposal to redevelop 22 of BEST's 27 bus depots under a public-private partnership (PPP) model was cleared by the BMC general body on Wednesday.

As reported by HT on August 5, the ambitious plan was chalked out to revive the cash-strapped undertaking by redeveloping the bus depots into mixed-use urban hubs. The redevelopment is part of BEST's ₹28,000-crore "turnaround" revival and modernisation plan.

The proposal, however, faced strong criticism in the House with the Opposition warning against "privatising" BEST's assets. Congress group leader Ashraf Azmi urged the BMC to develop the depots itself instead of handing them to private players.

However, BEST general manager Sonia Sethi said the redevelopment was needed to modernise the undertaking, including upgrading depots, introducing charging infrastructure and improving amenities. →P4

BJP MINISTER NAIK OPPOSED TO DATA CENTRES IN RESIDENTIAL AREAS

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MUMBAI: Amid a major push to develop the Mumbai Metropolitan Region into the country's leading data centre hub, senior BJP leader and forest minister Ganesh Naik said he is opposed to data centres being set up in residential areas and encouraged citizens to challenge them in court.

Naik's comments come amid a massive pushback by citizens against data centres being set up in Thane. →P4

10 acres around SGNP to make way for arts institute

Yogesh Naik

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MUMBAI: Over 10 acres of the eco-sensitive zone on the periphery of Sanjay Gandhi National Park (SGNP) will be used to construct the Indian Institute of Creative Technologies' (IICT) second campus.

The expert advisory committee of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change cleared the proposal recently.

IICT is an initiative of the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting. →P3



The proposed site is located 900 meters away from the periphery of Sanjay Gandhi National Park. SATISH BATE/HT PHOTO

RIJIJU: CONFUSION ARISES AS BORDER WITH CHINA NOT DEMARCATED

NEW DELHI: Parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju has said people living on either side of the LAC in some areas of Arunachal Pradesh have differing perceptions of the boundary because it is not demarcated, leading to some confusion. He trashed reports suggesting China had intruded 60km into Indian territory. "Our people believe that our land extends further ahead, while the villages situated on the China side... claim that their land extends deep inside here..." he told news agency IANS. →P6



16 YRS AFTER ADARSH, BAN ON GOVT LAND TO HSG SOCS LIFTED

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MUMBAI: Nearly 16 years after the Adarsh Housing Society scam surfaced, the Maharashtra government has decided to lift the ban on allotting government land to cooperative housing societies by introducing a fresh policy that replaces the latter system with direct allocations.

Under the proposed policy, government land will be auctioned to housing societies through a bidding process. →P5

J&K an important part of India: Gor in Srinagar

NEW DELHI: US ambassador Sergio Gor on Wednesday described Jammu and Kashmir as an "important part of India" during a visit to Srinagar, prompting Pakistan to summon the senior-most American diplomat in Islamabad to register a protest.

Gor, the first US ambassador to travel to Jammu and Kashmir in six years, made the remarks after a meeting with CM Omar Abdullah. He also indicated that the US could look into downgrading a travel advisory for Kashmir in view of the improvement in the situation in the region. "This is an important part of India and so I



J&K CM Omar Abdullah with US Ambassador Sergio Gor. ANI

am here visiting for the first time. It is an incredibly beautiful place and I'm thrilled to see this place," Gor said while speaking to the media along with Abdullah. →P6

10-YEAR-OLD GIRL RAPED, MURDERED BY HER NEIGHBOUR; ARRESTED: POLICE

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PUNE: A 10-year-old girl was allegedly raped and murdered by her neighbour in Pune, police said, adding that the 25-year-old accused has been arrested.

The incident took place on Tuesday in Pimpalwandi village. Pune rural SP Sandip Singh Gill said the accused lured the girl to a farm on the pretext of offering her fruit. "He allegedly took her to a field, where he allegedly raped her and strangled her to death," he said. →P6

MRNA VACCINE CUTS RECURRENCE OF MELANOMA IN CRUCIAL TRIAL

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NEW DELHI: Merck and Moderna announced on Wednesday morning that a bespoke mRNA cancer vaccine, given alongside Merck's blockbuster immunotherapy Keytruda after surgery, significantly reduced disease recurrence and metastasis in patients whose high-risk melanoma had just been surgically removed, compared to Keytruda alone. The news sent Moderna shares soaring 144% while Merck's stock climbed more than 11%. →P2

{ SRI LANKA SERIES }

Fillip for India's test championship hopes after commanding Galle win

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KOLKATA: Manav Suthar took 10 wickets as India beat Sri Lanka by 165 runs in Galle on Wednesday, pocketing 12 crucial World Test Championship points to stay in the race for next year's final.

The win pushed India's points percentage from 48.14% to 53.33%. They, however, remain fifth in the WTC standings, behind Australia (77.77%), South Africa (75.00%), New Zealand (72.22%) and Bangla-



Manav Suthar took 10 wickets.

desh (66.67%). If India win their eight remaining Tests in the cycle, their points percentage could hit 74.07%, putting them in a strong position for the final. →P11

INDIA DEFEAT PAK 5-3, QUALIFY FOR SECOND ROUND IN HOCKEY WC

Skipper Harmanpreet Singh and striker Abhishek scored a brace each as India extended their decade-long unbeaten run over arch-rivals Pakistan with a 5-3 win in a high-voltage FIH World Cup Pool D match in Amstelveen, Netherlands on Wednesday to advance to the second round of the tournament. The defeat ended Pakistan's campaign in the tournament. →P12

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{ BUSINESS } FUNDS DIVERSION

CBI books Gensol, BluSmart founders



The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has registered a case against Gensol Engineering (GEL), its promoters and founders of ride-hailing service BluSmart Anmol Singh Jaggi and Puneet Singh Jaggi, and others for alleged misutilisation and diversion of funds borrowed from the Indian Renewable Energy Development Agency (IREDA). The FIR, filed on July 31, also names sister concern Gensol EV Lease Ltd and unidentified persons. The CBI case follows findings by the Sebi and IREDA concerning alleged diversion of funds raised for the purchase of electric vehicles. The Enforcement Directorate (ED) is conducting a parallel money-laundering probe against the Jaggis. **PTI**

{ SPORT } 'HUGE MISTAKE'

Kyrgios fails cocaine test, gets suspended



Former Wimbledon finalist Nick Kyrgios was provisionally suspended from tennis on Wednesday after testing positive for cocaine, with the volatile Australian owning up to his "huge mistake" in a public apology. The International Tennis Integrity Agency (ITIA) announced the suspension of the 31-year-old following a positive test for a cocaine metabolite, benzoylecgonine, from a sample taken during an ATP 250 event in Mallorca in June. "I made a huge mistake and I take full responsibility for it," Kyrgios said on Instagram. **REUTERS**

{ WORLD } CRIMINAL PROBE ORDERED

Israeli military admits firing on car in death of Hind Rajab



The Israeli military on Wednesday admitted its troops fired on a car carrying five-year-old Hind Rajab in Gaza in 2024, saying it had ordered a criminal investigation into the killing which drew international outrage. Hind Rajab's body was recovered from a car riddled with bullets in Gaza City days after she was last heard from in a desperate, hours-long phone call to the Palestinian Red Crescent on January 29, 2024. The Israeli military had previously denied its troops were present in the area near the incident. The military said it was launching a criminal probe into the 2025 killings of 15 Palestinians, including humanitarian personnel. **PTI**

{ MY INDIA } BHAGWANPURIA GANG

Indian added to FBI wanted criminal list



The FBI is on the lookout for Major Singh, an Indian national allegedly involved in narcotics and illegal arms smuggling, and has placed him on the list of "wanted" criminals. Singh is linked to the Jaggu Bhagwanpuria organised crime group, which originated in Punjab, and operated in California and elsewhere, FBI said. "Major Singh is wanted for his alleged involvement in a transnational criminal organisation engaged in racketeer influenced and corrupt organisations conspiracy..." the agency said in a statement on Tuesday. **PTI**

{ WORLD } FRANK BEARD

Boogie-rock trio ZZ Top's drummer dies



Frank Beard, the drummer for the Texas boogie-rock trio ZZ Top who kept the tempo for the band's biggest hits like "Sharp Dressed Man," "Gimme All Your Lovin'" and "Legs," has died. He was 77. Beard was in hospice care when he died Tuesday at his ranch in Richmond, Texas, according to publicist Bob Merlis. Band co-founder and guitarist Billy Gibbons, on tour with bassist Elwood Francis, hailed Beard in a statement. ZZ Top sold more than 50 million records and had six singles that reached No. 1 on Billboard's Mainstream Rock Airplay chart. Seven of their albums have been in the Billboard 200's Top 10 and they earned three Grammy Award nominations. **AP**

MRNA jab cuts recurrence of melanoma in landmark trial

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NEW DELHI: Merck and Moderna announced on Wednesday morning that a bespoke mRNA cancer vaccine, given alongside Merck's blockbuster immunotherapy Keytruda after surgery, significantly reduced disease recurrence and metastasis in patients whose high-risk melanoma had just been surgically removed, compared to Keytruda alone.

The Phase 3 INTERpath-001 trial enrolled 1,137 patients across stages IIB to IV and hit both its primary endpoint on recurrence-free survival and its secondary milestone on distant metastasis at a pre-specified interim analysis. The companies have not yet released the hazard ratios — the statistical measure of how successful the vaccine has been — pending presentation at a medical meeting, but the decision to halt the trial for efficacy at interim analysis signals a breakthrough.

The news sent Moderna shares soaring 144% to \$153.69 while Merck's stock climbed more than 11% to \$150.19. In plain terms, this is the sort of landmark that cancer research has been chasing for three decades in general, and the mRNA platform since its blockbuster Covid-19 success in 2020.

Three firsts

One: It is the first Phase 3 win



Moderna's share prices surged nearly 144% in the US stock market, at the time of going to print. Merck's stock climbed more than 11% **AFP**

— Phase 3 being the largest and most rigorous stage of drug testing, in which a candidate goes head-to-head against the standard of care — for an individualised neoantigen therapy, a class of medicine in which each patient receives a treatment manufactured specifically for their own tumour. The concept has been argued about in immunology journals since the mid-1990s; it has taken until now to produce a randomised trial that beats a standard of care.

Two, it is the first regimen to demonstrably improve on Keytruda alone in the adjuvant setting — adjuvant meaning treatment given after surgery to mop up residual disease before it becomes clinically visible. Since 2019, a queue of experimental combinations — LAG-3 inhibitors, TIGIT blockers, oncolytic viruses — have

tried to add benefit on top of Keytruda and failed.

Three, and most crucially: this is the proof the mRNA field had been waiting for. The Covid-19 vaccines established that mRNA could be manufactured at planetary scale and safely instruct human cells to produce a target protein on demand. What those vaccines did not settle was whether the platform could do anything therapeutically important beyond infectious disease. That question has hung over the sector for five years, dragging Moderna's revenues down as pandemic demand receded. INTERpath-001 is the first Phase 3 study to answer it in the affirmative.

Why cancer vaccines had been a graveyard

Almost every previous cancer vaccine has failed. Melacine, GVAX, Stimuvax, rindopepimut — each generation from the 1990s onward tried to teach the immune system to attack tumours and each hit the same wall at Phase 3. The vaccines were made off the shelf, targeting proteins over-expressed on cancer cells but also present on healthy tissue. Either the immune system refused to attack because it recognised the target as self, or it attacked and caused autoimmune disease.

The individualised neoantigen approach negates that trade-off. Cancer cells accumu-

late mutations that produce abnormal proteins; the fragments those proteins are chopped into and displayed on the tumour surface are called neoantigens — molecular mugshots unique to that tumour and absent from healthy tissue. Intismeran autogene is a strand of synthetic messenger RNA that codes for up to 34 of a patient's own tumour neoantigens.

Why this jab may be different

Once injected, the mRNA functions as instructions the body's own cells read and translate into those proteins, which are then displayed to the immune system to recognise.

The Keytruda given alongside is a checkpoint inhibitor: it blocks a molecular handshake cancer cells use to signal "friend, not foe" and switch off attacking T-cells.

Keytruda's arrival in clinical practice a decade ago was most publicly demonstrated when it drove former US president Jimmy Carter's metastatic melanoma, which had spread to his brain and liver, into full remission in December 2015.

The two mechanisms are complementary: the vaccine teaches the immune system what a tumour looks like; the checkpoint inhibitor stops the tumour from silencing the T-cells that have learned to recognise it.

China shows off robotics might

The 2026 World Robot Conference opened in Beijing on Wednesday, with Chinese giants showing off their innovations — amid doubts over their readiness for work.

THE SHOW

The five-day event features over 300 companies, 2,000 exhibits and 150-plus product launches, according to Beijing authorities. To be sure, no other countries were exhibiting, despite the "World" in the conference's name.

WHAT THEY SHOWED

Unitree robots boxed, danced and played ping-pong against a human.

UBTECH's emotional-care humanoid — priced at \$24,000 — talks, makes facial expressions, moves its neck and hands, said deputy president Jiao Jichao.

Leju's robots sort crates in European and domestic auto plants, matching human efficiency, said assistant vice-president Zhang Dapeng.

Robotera's wheeled parcel-sorting torso runs 900–1,000 hours continuously at 85% of human effectiveness, a sales representative told Reuters.

DexForce robots packaged phones into boxes.

A helper robot at one booth tried for several minutes to fold a shirt. It failed.

IN WAKE OF U.S. BAN

The event follows a US ban, announced weeks earlier, on imports of new foreign-made humanoid and quadruped robots and power inverters, citing cybersecurity and national security risks — a move aimed at China.

UNITREE STOCK SURGES

Shares in Unitree surged 460% in their Shanghai trading debut after the company raised 6.1 billion yuan (\$904 million) in an IPO that will make it the first publicly traded humanoid robot maker in mainland China. The closing price gave Unitree a market value of 342 billion yuan.



{ SINHAGAD FORT }

After attack on tourists, forest dept to regulate entry at fort

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PUNE: Once the number of visitors to Sinhagad fort reaches its safe carrying capacity, the forest department will regulate entry to the fort besides increasing security at high-footfall points and introducing an app-based system to monitor crowd levels and entry.

The move comes after eight persons allegedly assaulted a group of tourists at the fort on Sunday, August 16, following an argument over the attire of an eight-year-old girl and photographing a memorial site. The aim is to prevent recurrence of such incidents, ease congestion, and ensure the safety of visitors.

The said incident occurred at around 2 pm on Sunday when the fort witnessed a large influx of visitors due to the extended weekend and ongoing monsoon. As per the complaint registered at Haveli police station, the complainant, Avdhat Pandurang Patil, 39, a resident of Dhayari, had visited the fort with his wife and son; along with a friend, and the friend's wife and daughter when a group of seven to eight men and women associated with a right-wing group identified as Samast Hindu Bandhav (SHB) Army allegedly confronted Patil and the members of his group. They questioned him over the eight-year-old girl's wearing of bermuda shorts and objected to photographs being taken near the memorial site. The accused allegedly told Patil and members of his group that they did not understand Hindu culture and subsequently assaulted them with their bare hands and a plastic stick. Some other tourists



The incident occurred at around 2 pm on Sunday when the fort witnessed a large influx of visitors due to the extended weekend and ongoing monsoon. **HT FILE PHOTO**

present at the spot were also allegedly assaulted.

Patil subsequently approached the police personnel deployed in the parking area and informed them about the assault. Assistant police inspector Sunita Chavre and other personnel on duty intervened and brought the situation under control. Patil later approached Haveli police station and lodged a formal complaint with a case being registered against the eight accused — identified as Sanket Sanjay Patil, originally from Mandruli Koli in Patan taluka of Satara district; and seven others — under sections 115(2), 118(1), 189(2), 191(2) and 351(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Haveli police station inspector Rajesh Ramagare said that the offences attract provisions under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) and notices have been served to the accused in accordance with the same.

Sandip Singh Gill, superintendent of police, Pune rural, said that personnel deployed at

the fort handled the situation promptly and directed the accused to appear at the police station. "The police are investigating the circumstances leading to the altercation and the role of each of the eight accused," Gill said. Meanwhile, the Raje Shivraj Pratishthan has sought enhanced security and crowd-management measures at Sinhagad fort following the incident. Manoj Barbole, range forest officer, Pune forest division, said, "Until a permanent carrying-capacity based system is implemented, entry to Sinhagad will be regulated once the safe visitor capacity is reached. The number of security personnel deployed at high-footfall points will be increased, while an app-based system providing information on crowd levels and entry is also in the final stages of development".

The forest department said that Sinhagad fort is not merely a tourist destination but an important part of the region's historical heritage, making the visitors' safety a shared responsibility.

Urban planners join fight to save Bandra's football ground

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MUMBAI: A group of urban planners and architects has urged the urban development department to reject the proposed modification in Development Plan 2034 that will change the reservation of the Neville D'Souza Football Ground in Bandra from a playground/maiden and open-space reservation to an exhibition and convention centre. The change in reservation was cleared in the BMC general body meeting on Tuesday.

In a representation dated August 19 to the principal secretary of the urban development department-1, the group which calls itself 'Urban Centre Mumbai', said the proposed conversion would result in the loss of a valuable public open space in a city already severely deficient in such amenities. The group said it was "deeply concerned" by the proposed conversion of an existing playground/maiden into an exhibition or convention centre, sports complex or any other built-up, non-open-space or privatised use.

According to the planners, the BMC's own assessment during the preparation of DP 2034 had acknowledged a severe deficiency in public open spaces across Mumbai. The city was found to have only around 0.88 square metres of open space per capita compared with the 10-12 square metres per capita recommended under the Urban and Regional Development Plans Formulation and Implementation (URDPFI) guidelines for large cities and around nine square metres recommended by the World Health Organisation.



Despite recognising the shortage, the planners said, the DP 2034 had failed to adequately address the gap between reservation, acquisition, protection or augmentation of public open spaces. The representation was signed by the group's principal director Pankaj Joshi, and Urmi Kenia, director, spatial planning and community development.

The group also questioned the planning basis for the proposed change, stating that there was no supporting preparatory study or evidence establishing the need for an exhibition or convention centre at the particular location. It argued that converting an open space reservation into a built-up use represented a fundamental shift from protecting public open spaces towards their systematic conversion.

The planners said the proposal should not be evaluated merely on whether a commercial or built-up activity could physically be accommodated on the plot. "Land available for public open

GROUP OF URBAN PLANNERS AND ARCHITECTS SAID THE PROPOSAL TO CONVERT GROUND INTO CONVENTION CENTRE IS DEEPLY CONCERNING

spaces is extremely scarce and cannot be viewed merely as another development opportunity," the representation stated, arguing that once such land was diverted towards commercial exploitation, the resulting loss of public amenity would not be readily reversible.

The group further warned that the step could create a precedent for other public open spaces to face similar dilution or commercial exploitation. Treating each proposal as an isolated case, it said, would ignore the cumulative impact of the loss of open spaces across the city.

The planners have also called for the cumulative ward-level deficiency in open spaces to be considered before any change in reservation is approved. They said the planning authorities and the Improvement Committee needed to establish, through transparent and verifiable data, that the affected ward had adequate public open-space provisions before permitting any proposal that reduced, commercialised or otherwise compromised an existing public open space.

The representation also raised constitutional and legal concerns, stating that the proposal could have implications for the Right to Life under Article 21, which includes the right to a clean and healthy environment, as well as Article 14, if the decision is found to be arbitrary or inconsistent with established planning norms. It also invoked environmental safeguards and the Public Trust Doctrine, under which public spaces and resources are held by the State in trust for public use.

BOSS' STERN BEHAVIOUR IS NOT ABETMENT TO SUICIDE, SAYS SC

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has held that ordinary administrative directions, disciplinary supervision, adverse remarks on an official's performance, even stern behaviour by a superior, however unpleasant they may have been perceived by the deceased, cannot by themselves be elevated to the offence of abetment of suicide under the penal law.

A bench of justices Satish Chandra Sharma and N Kotiswar Singh said that there must be additional material demonstrating a conscious intention to drive a subordinate to commit suicide.

"Criminal liability under Section 306 of the IPC (abetment to suicide) cannot rest upon the tragedy of the outcome alone; it must be founded upon the statutory ingredients of Section 306, which are absent in the present case," said the bench while discharging a senior forest officer accused of abetting the suicide of a woman forest range officer.

The judgment, released earlier this week, came in an appeal filed by Vinod Shivakumar, then deputy conservator of forests, against the HC's refusal to interfere with criminal proceedings against him. The Supreme Court set aside the high court and trial court orders and discharged Shivakumar from the case. The case arose from the suicide on March 25, 2021, of a forest range officer posted in the Harisar Range in Maharashtra. She shot herself with her official weapon and left behind three suicide notes. The notes specifically blamed Shivakumar for her death.

The Supreme Court, however, said that abetment requires direct or indirect instigation in close proximity to the suicide and clear mens rea to abet its commission.

Two more held for fuelling ₹10.4-crore INOX ‘Boss Scam’

The accused supplied SIMs to fraudsters who posed as ‘bosses’ to convince corporate executives to part with company money

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MUMBAI: Police have arrested two more individuals in the ₹10.4-crore INOX Group cheating case, both of them linked to the “Boss Scams”, where fraudsters have been getting corporate executives to transfer large sums of money from their companies to mule bank accounts on instructions of their “bosses”. In each instance, the “boss” has been a fraudster impersonating a senior corporate executive.

The two arrests, made by the South Cyber police, take the total number of arrests in the INOX

case to ten. Police said the accused had supplied SIM cards used in the crime, where fraudsters convinced a senior accounts executive to transfer ₹10.4 crore into mule bank accounts, by posing as a senior director of the group. Police said the accused were involved in at least five similar “Boss Scams”.

The two arrested accused are Amir Chand Mohammad Khan (22), a resident of Siwan in Bihar, and Suraj Kumar Pradeep Kumar Saw aka Vishal (22), a resident of Dhanbad in Jharkhand, said deputy commissioner of police, cyber, Bajrang Bansode. He said 161 SIM cards were seized from them.

“While investigating the INOX Group cheating case, we had earlier arrested eight people and frozen around ₹6 crore in various bank accounts. The two accused played a crucial role in providing the fraudsters with mobile SIM cards used in various crimes,” said Bansode.



July 1, 2026: HT report on the six people who were arrested for defrauding INOX Group executive

FRAUDSTERS HAD CONVINCED A SENIOR ACCOUNTS EXECUTIVE TO TRANSFER ₹10.4 CRORE, BY POSING AS A SENIOR DIRECTOR OF THE GROUP

and transferred the money.

The WhatsApp number from which messages were sent to Amin had used the name and display picture of the director to support the impersonation, police said. The WhatsApp conversation started with the fraudster informing the accounts executive that he was attending an important meeting and would call him later. Then he told Amin to transfer ₹46.5 lakh to a certain bank account.

“Between June 3 and 15, Amin allegedly acted on similar What-

sApp instructions and transferred money from the company’s accounts,” said the police officer. “The fraud came to light when Amin contacted the INOX Group director to seek invoices for the money transferred. The director said he had never instructed Amin to transfer any money,” said the police officer.

Police said one of the accused, Amir Chand Mohammad Khan, ran a mobile shop in Siwan. He had been approached by an army jawan to port his mobile number. Khan issued a fresh SIM card, but told the jawan the porting had failed. Khan then sold the SIM card to the other accused, Suraj Saw, from whom the SIM card made its way to the Boss Scam fraudsters.

Police said Khan had similarly supplied SIM cards in the Mega Pipes fraud case, in which an accountant was instructed to transfer ₹48 lakh by scamsters posing as a director of the company, in February.

10 acres around SGNP cleared for arts institute

Yogesh Naik

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MUMBAI: Over 10 acres of the eco-sensitive zone on the periphery of Sanjay Gandhi National Park (SGNP) will be used to construct the Indian Institute of Creative Technologies’ (IICT) second campus – its primary campus is at Pedder Road. The expert advisory committee (EAC) of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) cleared the proposal earlier this month.

The proposed site is located 900 meters away from the periphery of SGNP – from where many animals and birds migrate to the eco-sensitive zone.

IICT was launched in Mumbai during the WAVES (World Audio Visual & Entertainment Summit) in 2025. It is an initiative of the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting. The institute, which is located in the NFDC building at Pedder Road, was envisioned as a national hub for animation, visual effects, gaming and comics (AVGC).

Several tech giants, including NVIDIA, Google, Apple, Microsoft, Meta, Star India, and Adobe, have partnered with IICT to collaborate on course development and training initiatives, to make it a national centre of excellence modelled along the lines of premier institutions such as IITs and IIMs.

In a recent meeting, members of EAC were told by the state government that the proposal



The proposed site is located 900m away from the periphery of the Sanjay Gandhi National Park.
REPRESENTATIONAL PIC

was first considered by the standing committee of the National Board for Wildlife (SC-NBWL) in its 89th meeting held on February 28, 2026. It was deferred as the approval of the zonal master plan (ZMP) for the eco-sensitive zone was pending. As the project was a Central government push, the EAC asked the state government to prepare and approve the ZMP.

According to the minutes of the EAC meeting, a copy of which is with HT, the chief wildlife warden assured that the IICT project was in consonance with the ZMP approved for the eco-sensitive zone of SGNP.

As part of the conditions, IICT has been asked to deposit 2% of the project cost attributable to the eco-sensitive zone of SGNP towards wildlife conservation and protection with the SGNP conservator.

The EAC has mandated that the institute construct a 3-metre-high compound wall, along with a 1-metre chain-link or barbed-wire fence and safety reinforcements along the project boundary to minimize human-wildlife conflict.

Criticising the move, environmentalist D Stalin, of NGO Van-shakti, said: “The ESZ monitoring committee is a joke – it does not do anything to protect forests or environment. It only creates openings to help violators. There is no logical explanation about why an institution should come up here after chopping trees.”

In January this year, the State Board for Wildlife cleared a road project from Magathane to Kandivali, which requires diversion through 2.59 hectares in SGNP and 0.59 hectares from its eco-sensitive zone.

MMRDA halts recruitment, orders probe

HT Correspondent

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MUMBAI: A day after candidates raised questions over the provisional merit list of its recruitment examination, the Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority (MMRDA) on Wednesday constituted a three-member committee to independently examine the complaints and objections and put further action in the recruitment process on hold until the inquiry is completed.

The committee will be headed by former Maharashtra chief secretary Johnny Joseph, with professors Shyamprasad Kargade and Dasaka Satyanarayana Murthy of IIT Bombay as members. The move follows com-

plaints received by MMRDA after it declared the provisional results of its recruitment drive for 235 vacant posts. A total of 26,749 candidates had applied for the recruitment, while 20,459 appeared for the online examination conducted by Tata Consultancy Services (TCS).

The scrutiny was particularly sought for the examination for 82 junior engineer (JE) posts, after candidates pointed out that 13 of the top 20 scorers had been allotted the same examination centre in Nagpur on May 12. Candidates had also flagged significant differences between the scores of some candidates in the MMRDA examination and their performance in other government recruitment examinations.

MMRDA, however, main-



August 19, 2026: HT report on questions being raised over perfect top scorers in MMRDA’s Mumbai, Pune recruitment exams.

tained that the recruitment process was conducted in accordance with the rules and procedures prescribed by the Maharashtra government and said there had been no change in its position regarding the conduct of the

examination.

In a statement issued on Wednesday, the authority said it had decided to have the complaints independently examined “to address the concerns and remove any doubts about the recruitment process”. It has also sought clarification from TCS.

Candidates with complaints, objections or comments regarding the recruitment process have been asked to submit their representations, along with supporting evidence and relevant documents, within 30 days. The committee will examine these before submitting its final report.

The MMRDA JE examination was conducted by TCS on May 11 and 12 across centres in eight districts of Maharashtra. The JE

recruitment had attracted 14,714 applications for 82 posts.

Reacting to the decision, Maharashtra Pradesh Congress Committee (MPCC) general secretary Dhananjay Ramkrishna Shinde said the Congress had been raising the issue for the past six days “for the justice of the students”. He said the decision to appoint a high-level committee and stop further proceedings was a recognition of the party’s demand.

However, Shinde said the committee should go beyond verifying candidates’ complaints and conduct an independent technical investigation into the entire examination process, including the scoring process, CCTV footage, digital logs and the role of TCS.

9 fishermen rescued off Mum coast

MUMBAI: The Mumbai Police coastal wing rescued nine fishermen after their fishing boat developed an engine failure and began taking on water nearly 25 nautical miles off the Mumbai coast on Wednesday morning.

The incident came to light after deputy commissioner (transport) Nimba Patil received an alert from the South Control Room. He immediately alerted the coastal wing, which dis-

patched Static Boat No. 15 to the spot around 11am.

Sub-inspector Dharmendra Kumar of the coastal police wing said the rescue operation was carried out despite rough sea conditions.

“The sea was rough, yet we dispatched a boat to rescue them at 11am. We rescued all nine persons and later towed their boat back to Mumbai,” Kumar said.

YOGESH NAIK





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GUEST OF HONOUR

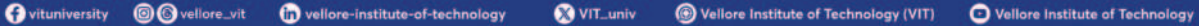
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Colaba school lacks basic items, infra, finds CJP



On Wednesday, 10-12 CJP volunteers visited the Colaba Market School and interacted with students and staff. RAJU SHINDE/HT

Niraj Pandit

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MUMBAI: The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation's (BMC) Colaba Market School has no CCTV cameras or sanitary pads for female students, volunteers from the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) found on Wednesday during the outfit's first programme in the city under the nationwide 'School Thik Karo' campaign.

The school, which has 1,294 students in classes 1-8, also grapples with a shortage of teachers, computers and other learning facilities. Fire extinguishers and first-aid facilities in the school are inadequate, while textbooks, notebooks, scholarships and other financial assistance for eligible students are not always readily available, as per the 24-point report card prepared by CJP volunteers following their visit.

Akshay Shinde, CJP's national coordinator who also visited the school, said that their overall assessment indicated the school needed improvement. The report would be submitted to the concerned authorities and they would be given one month to address the problems, he said.

"Our aim is to improve school infrastructure. We are visiting schools across the country and giving a one-month ultimatum to the authorities to improve facilities," Shinde told reporters.

HT had, in August 2025, reported on problems students at the school were encountering, including an unsafe building which was subsequently pulled down, with students being



AUGUST 5, 2025: HT report on students being forced to shift to online classes after the building was declared unsafe.

moved to another building in the vicinity.

On Wednesday, around 10-12 CJP volunteers visited the Colaba Market School around 3pm, accompanied by several independent activists. As per the report card prepared by the CJP team, the school has an adequate supply of clean drinking water and electricity. Student attendance is also satisfactory and mid-day meals are provided to students regularly.

The report card, however, raised concern over the condition of toilets, safety of the school building, and the lack of adequate teachers, resulting in disruptions in regular teaching as per the timetable.

Basic facilities for students with disabilities as well as CCTV cameras were not available, nor were sanitary pads provided to female students, the report card said.

Shinde said that when CJP volunteers asked the school in-charge to show them the latest requisition for sanitary pads, a three-year-old letter was produced.

No data centres near homes: Naik

Forest minister says citizens must move court even as CM's plans to make MMR a data centre hub

Saurabha Kulshreshtha
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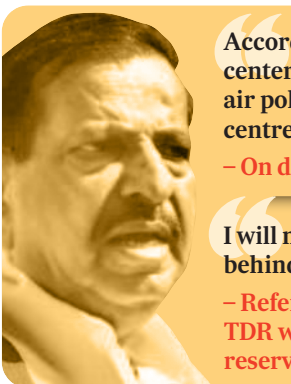
MUMBAI: Senior BJP leader and forest minister Ganesh Naik said he is opposed to data centres being set up in residential areas and encouraged citizens resisting them to challenge them in court. Naik's comments come amid a massive pushback against data centres being set up in Thane, where citizens and activists are campaigning against their environmental impact and the diversion of essential resources such as water and electricity.

Naik expressed his views at a Janata Darbar (people's court) in Thane on Wednesday. "We need

data centres. But since they affect people's lives through noise and air pollution, and require large amounts of water, I think data centres should not be set up in residential areas. People opposing them should also go to court," he said.

The protests in Thane concern data centres proposed in Balkum, Majiwada and Dhokali, particularly one currently being built by Amazon Web Services on a 54-acre plot in Balkum. Protestors, who have been demonstrating for the last two months, point out that the facility is in the midst of residential complexes, schools, hospitals and other community infrastructure. On Wednesday, citizens appealed to Naik to get the data centre shifted out of the locality. He said he understood their concerns and would take up the matter with chief minister Devendra Fadnavis.

Naik's stand must be seen against the backdrop of Fadnavis's ambitions for the Mumbai



According to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, we need data centers. But since they affect people's lives through noise and air pollution, and require large amounts of water, I think data centres should not be set up in residential areas

— On data centres

I will not name anyone but people should find out who is behind this. It is not good to do such things for personal gain

— Referring to the "thousands of flats" that will be built from TDR worth ₹2,800 crore allotted to a private company for reserve forest land

Metropolitan Region (MMR), of which Thane is an integral part. An ambitious ₹16.7 lakh crore plan is currently underway to develop MMR into the country's leading data centre hub, a region that will eventually host 60% of India's data centres, Fadnavis had said in June. The CM aims to transform the MMR into a massive growth driver. A September 2024 NITI Aayog report projected the region to emerge as one

of the world's leading metropolitan economies with a GDP approaching \$1.5 trillion by 2047, the centennial year of India's independence. To achieve this target, the region needs to consistently attract investments worth \$135 billion over seven years. The state expects digital infrastructure and data centres to power this growth.

Addressing the media after Wednesday's Janata Darbar,

Naik said, "According to PM Narendra Modi, we need data centers. But I am of the view that they should not be set up in residential areas. Data centres need huge amounts of electricity and water, and create air pollution. They have adverse effects on people's lives and should not be set up in residential areas." The senior BJP minister added, "People in Thane opposing data centres met me today and expressed

their concerns. I told them I would convey their views to chief minister. But along with raising the issue on a political and administrative level, it needs to be challenged in court. If protestors challenge data centers in residential areas in court, I think the courts will definitely consider the environmental issues and adverse effects on public life."

Naik held the Janata Darbar in the Gadkari Rangayatan auditorium in Thane city, home turf of his arch rival, deputy chief minister Eknath Shinde.

Naik slammed the Shiv Sena-nurled Thane Municipal Corporation (TMC) over TDR worth ₹2,800 crore being allotted to a private company in lieu of reserve forest land acquired from it. He said the value of TDR could be ₹4,000 crore, not ₹2,800 crore. Naik said, "I will not name anyone but people should find out who is behind this. It is not good to do such things for personal gain."

WR shuts 22 food stalls over hygiene lapses

Shashank Rao

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MUMBAI: Amid the Food and Drug Administration's (FDA) ongoing crackdown on restaurants and eateries over hygiene lapses and substandard food, Western Railway (WR) has shut 22 food stalls at suburban stations after inspections found irregularities in food quality, sanitation and maintenance. The railway administration has also ordered deep cleaning of all 450 food stalls along the Churchgate-Virar corridor.

The action has affected stalls at some of the busiest stations, including Bandra, Lower Parel and Charni Road. Sources said inspections of food stalls across suburban stations began earlier this month, with outlets selling prepared food such as chole, samosa and vada coming under particular scrutiny. "During inspections, we found that the quality of food at these stalls failed to meet prescribed standards. Sanitation conditions at many outlets were also poor. Furthermore, several stall workers lacked the required medical



The action has affected stalls at some of the busiest stations. HT

certificates—for instance, at one stall with four workers, only two held valid medical certification," said a WR official, speaking on condition of anonymity.

Following the inspections, action was taken against stalls found to be non-compliant and they have been given time to rectify the shortcomings. Until then, the affected outlets have been permitted to sell only packaged food items. "We have issued notices to these food stalls. We will begin with deep cleaning of 450 food stalls across the suburban network," said another WR official. As part of the cleaning

drive, WR will use jet-pump pipes along with water and cleaning chemicals to thoroughly clean the stalls.

"The food stalls at stations are regularly monitored and maintained with routine hygiene, cleanliness and maintenance measures being carried out to ensure proper standards. It has nothing to do with FDA crackdown," maintained a WR official. A stall employee said workers had been explicitly instructed to prioritise cleanliness and food quality, with strict action warned against future negligence.

FDA restores licence of BMC canteen after 19 lapses rectified

Osama Rawal

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MUMBAI: The Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has revoked the suspension of the food licence of the canteen at the BMC headquarters Annex building, nearly a month after it was shut down for 22 food-safety and hygiene-related non-compliances, including a fly being found in a glass of buttermilk.

The FDA revoked the suspension after the canteen operator, Kamal Caterers, demonstrated substantial compliance with the deficiencies flagged during inspections. While a re-verification on August 2 found that 12 of the 22 deficiencies were still pending, a subsequent inspection on August 13 found that only three remained. These three were

related to the retention of documents and records under the licence conditions.

The FDA also recorded that deficiencies concerning pest control, cleaning, hygiene and staff training had been rectified. Following a hearing with the canteen management and submission of compliance documents, the FDA decided to restore the food licence.

The licence had been suspended on July 22, following inspections carried out after an improvement notice was issued to the canteen on June 9. In my view, effective food-safety regulation is at its strongest when strict statutory standards are accompanied by an equally objective and fair assessment of compliance," said advocate Dhruv Thakker, counsel for the appellant.

3-YEAR-OLD BOY BEATEN TO DEATH BY STEPFATHER

Sameera Kapoor Munshi

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NAVI MUMBAI: A three-year-old boy was allegedly beaten to death by his stepfather at their home in Uran's Mora area after he expressed a desire to go to his biological father, police said. The accused allegedly told doctors that the child had fallen from a bed, but a post-mortem later revealed multiple injuries and fractures, leading police to treat the death as homicide.

The deceased, Moksh Bhise, was allegedly assaulted by his stepfather, Jitendra Bhise, at their home in Phanawadi on August 14. Bhise, who married Moksh's mother, Kayva Mhatre, around one-and-a-half years ago, was arrested on August 15.

Police said Bhise took the unconscious child to Indira Gandhi Rural Hospital in Uran at around 4pm and claimed that he had fallen from the bed. Doctors declared Moksh dead soon after. Kayva was away when the incident occurred.

The accused allegedly left the hospital with the child's body. The hospital then alerted the police. When officers reached the family's home, they found that Bhise had allegedly begun preparations for the child's last rites. Police stopped the preparations and sent the body for a post-mortem which showed multiple injuries and fractures and doctors classified the death as homicidal death.

Police suspect that Bhise attacked the child after an argument in which Moksh expressed a desire to go to his biological father. They also learnt that Bhise allegedly frequently assaulted the boy over trivial matters and subjected him to physical and mental harassment because he was his stepson.

15-YEAR-OLD BOY WHO SKIPPED SCHOOL DROWNS IN WATERFALL

HT Correspondent

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NAVI MUMBAI: A 15-year-old Kurla boy drowned at Pandavkada waterfall in Kharghar on Wednesday morning after he reportedly went there with friends instead of school, police said. The deceased, identified as Pranav Rakesh Mishra, was found trapped in a rocky crevice around 10-12 feet underwater and was pulled out by firefighters after a search operation.

Pranav, who lived at Khot Chawl in Kurla West, had left home on Tuesday, August 18, telling his family he was going to school. Police said he instead travelled to Pandavkada waterfall with his friends, where he reportedly drowned.

According to the police, when he did not return home, his parents went to the Kurla police to lodge a missing person case. The police then received information from the Kharghar police department about a drowning incident.

A distress call about a person drowning was received by the CIDCO Kharghar fire station on Wednesday. A fire brigade team rushed to the waterfall and began searching the water.

Firefighters eventually located Pranav trapped in a rocky crevice at a depth of around 10 to 12 feet. They pulled him out and brought him down the hill on a stretcher.

He was taken to Panvel Rural Hospital, where doctors declared him dead. Kharghar police have registered an accidental death report under the BNSS.

BMC clears proposal to redevelop 22 BEST depots under PPP model

Osama Rawal

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MUMBAI: The BMC general body on Wednesday night cleared a proposal to redevelop 22 of BEST's 27 bus depots under a public-private partnership (PPP) model. Tabled as an urgent business motion, the proposal was cleared at around 12.35am following more than two hours of debate. The BEST committee had given its in-principle approval on August 4.

As reported by HT on August 5, the ambitious plan was chalked out to revive the cash-strapped undertaking by redeveloping the bus depots into mixed-use urban hubs.

"We are not selling or giving them away. We are leasing them. We have earlier also given plots on 999-year leases," said



22 out of BEST's 27 depots will be redeveloped. HT

Trushna Vishwasrao, chairperson of the BEST Committee.

BEST general manager Sonia Sethi said the redevelopment was necessary to modernise the undertaking, including upgrad-

ing depots, introducing charging infrastructure and improving amenities.

Sethi added that around 10,000 tenements would be developed for BEST employees. Trushna Vishwasrao added that ₹500 crore towards gratuity had already been released and would be used for gratuity payments.

The proposal, however, faced strong opposition in the House. Sena (UBT) corporator Yashodhar Phanse questioned the valuation of the properties at ₹28,000 crore and warned against "privatising" BEST's assets. He argued that the shift towards private wet-lease buses had already raised concerns over accidents, and said that PPP redevelopment could worsen the situation.

Congress group leader Ashraf



AUGUST 5, 2026: HT report on plans to redevelop BEST depots under PPP model

Azmi urged the BMC to develop the depots itself instead of handing them to private players. Opposition members also demanded a white paper on earlier attempts to privatise or commercially develop BEST depots since 2007, questioning what the undertaking had gained from those initiatives.

{ LIVELIHOODS AT STAKE }

Fishers to rally against proposed desalination plant at Manori

Linah Baliga

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MUMBAI: Concerned about the impact of the proposed desalination plant at Manori on the livelihoods of fisher communities, around 1,500 fishermen from Madh, Manori, Uttan and other villages along the city's western coastline are likely to participate in a rally on Friday to oppose the project.

The rally, organised by the Gorai Machimar Sahakari Sanstha along with the National Fishworkers' Forum and the Maharashtra Machimar Kruti Samiti, will commence at 9am from the Madh coastline and culminate at Uttan chowk. It will highlight the concerns of fisher communities regarding marine ecology, fish breeding and brine discharge from the proposed plant, said Oldin Vasaikar, chairman, Gorai Machimar Sahakari Sanstha.

"The desalination plant will discharge brine into the sea, which will affect fish breeding and plankton growth. The marine food chain will be



The Maharashtra Machimar Kruti Samiti and the Gorai Machimar Sahakari Sanstha hold regular interactions with local youth to sensitise them about the project.

impacted and availability of fresh catch will reduce drastically, impacting the livelihoods of thousands of fisherfolk," Vasaikar told Hindustan Times.

The desalination plant would also threaten small fish, which are likely to be pulled in when it draws sea water for desalination, Vasaikar said, citing the experiences of fisher communities in Chennai.

"Since a desalination plant has been operational in Chennai for several years, we spoke to

fishermen there and learnt that livelihoods of people in six villages have been affected," he said.

High impact

The proposed project comprises a 400 million litres per day (MLD) seawater reverse osmosis (SWRO) desalination plant. The plant will be developed in two phases of 200 MLD each, at a cost of ₹2,066 crore for the first phase and ₹1,371 crore for the second phase. Once operational, it will greatly augment Mum-

bai's water supply, and help combat shortage, especially when the monsoon is lean.

The proposed project area includes four fishing villages—Manori, Gorai, Uttan and Madh—with a combined population of 15,362, according to the 2010 state marine fisheries census. The census recorded 3,779 people engaged in fishing and allied activities in Uttan and 1,688 in Manori.

The Environment Impact Assessment (EIA) report for the project, a copy of which is with HT, conceded that nearly 70% of the population in the project area was directly or indirectly dependent on fishing and allied activities such as boat and catamaran repairs, net weaving and fish trading. Mussel collection, lobster fishing, shore-seine fishing, deep-sea fishing and other fishing-related activities were also major occupations, the report said.

The EIA's field assessment found approximately 200 motorised and 150 non-motorised fishing boats operating from Manori, while around 400 fish-

ing boats were engaged in fishing activities from Uttan.

According to the EIA report, prepared by the Israel-based water treatment solutions firm IDE Technologies, the volume of brine reject discharged from the plant into the sea would be 300 MLD during phase I and 600 MLD during phase II. The brine reject would have a mean salinity of 56.8 practical salinity unit (PSU), compared with the ambient seawater salinity of 35.5 PSU at the proposed intake location—a difference of 21.3 PSU.

Though the EIA report said that the discharge would comply with standards stipulated by the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) and Maharashtra Pollution Control Board (MPCB), fisherfolk in the project area are not convinced. "Our current catch will be affected. The discharged water will increase the salinity of seawater and could lead to fish dying," asserted Vasaikar.

He also alleged that though the report claims that local residents had demanded the desalination plant, no such demand was made by the fisherfolk.

Fisheries dept plans to appoint TISS for socio-economic survey

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MUMBAI: Amid increasing opposition from fishermen about various projects in MMR and coastal areas of Konkan, the fisheries department has decided to conduct a socio-economic survey of the fishermen's families. The department is likely to assign the responsibility to the Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS). The data will be used to decide compensation for fishermen affected by concerned projects in the future.

The department has also proposed a loan waiver for fishermen, similar to farmers, and an increase in compensation for the non-fishing period from the current ₹4500 to ₹20,000.

On Monday, fisheries min-

ister Nitesh Rane held a meeting regarding the compensation demands of fishermen affected by the Versova-Bandra Sea Link project. At the meeting Rane was told about the fishermen's unhappiness over the present compensation, with officials pointing out that BMC was offering higher compensation to those affected by the Coastal Road project.

It was then decided to conduct the socio-economic survey. "The government will examine the possibility of increasing the compensation. But for that we need a report on the socio-economic conditions of fishermen's families. Let TISS conduct this survey. We will decide on compensation after seeing the report," said Rane.

Fearing arrest, BJP corporators defer BMC panel meeting



The court has issued non-bailable warrants against five BJP corporators, including Prabhakar Shinde (L) and Akash Rajpurohit (R). Rajpurohit was arrested on August 5.



Osama Rawal

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MUMBAI: The BMC Standing Committee meeting scheduled for Wednesday was postponed due to BJP corporators, including the chairperson of the Standing Committee Prabhakar Shinde, fearing they would be arrested. The court had issued non-bailable warrants for the corporators in a previous hearing concerning a 2020 protest case.

The meeting was postponed against the backdrop of BJP corporator Akash Rajpurohit, who was taken into custody for reaching the court late for the previous hearing on August 5. Rajpurohit was subsequently remanded to court custody for two days.

Speaking to HT, Shinde said he had reached the court on Wednesday morning for the hearing, but it was scheduled for the afternoon. "When we exited the court, we were called again at 1.30 pm and we rushed there immediately," he said. "We were called at 2.45 pm initially. I thought it would not be possible to chair a meeting when I was in court so we postponed it to Thursday."

The meeting was abruptly called off around 2 pm on Wednesday, as the accused corporators had to remain available for the court proceedings. Two other corporators in the Standing Committee—Mahim corporator Sheetal Gambhir and education committee chairperson Rajshree Shirwadkar—are also accused in the case.

Rajpurohit, meanwhile, said that on Wednesday he had reached the court at 10.45 am,

before its scheduled starting time of 11 am. "The matter was put up later in the afternoon so I went to attend the BEST Committee meeting," he said. "I got a call at 1.15pm, saying that I had to come to the court. We were there in no time."

The case relates to a protest at BEST Bhavan during the Covid-19 lockdown, when BJP leaders and corporators had demanded that BEST waive six months of electricity bills. More than a dozen corporators were booked in connection with the protest, including legislative assembly speaker Rahul Narwekar and minister Mangal Prabhat Lodha.

According to the police case, Rajpurohit and 18 other corporators, including Lodha and Narwekar, had assembled at BEST Bhavan to protest against the electricity bill hike. The Colaba police booked them under provisions of the IPC, the Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act and the Epidemic Diseases Act. The accused had been facing the possibility of arrest after the court issued non-bailable warrants against the five BJP corporators on August 5, including Shinde and Rajpurohit. Rajpurohit was arrested after the last hearing while the warrants of the other four were cancelled later the same day. While remanding Rajpurohit to custody, Justice Mahesh Jadhav observed that this was the second occasion on which he had appeared late before the court. Rajpurohit, however, maintained that his delay was caused by an issue with the lift.

The Standing Committee meeting has now been rescheduled for Thursday at 3 pm.

BEST TO GET 150 DOUBLE-DECKER E-BUSES AFTER PAY HIKE NOD

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MUMBAI: AC double-decker buses are set to make a comeback after a delay of more than two years, with BEST agreeing to increase the payment to manufacturer Switch Mobility by ₹3.85 per km to resolve a long-standing contractual dispute.

The revision will take the lease rate to around ₹60 per km and pave the way for the delivery of the remaining 150 electric AC double-decker buses. BEST has already received 50 buses under the original contract.

Senior BEST officials said the additional payment is required to cover the cost of installing a safety device mandated by the Centre. The BEST administration has submitted a revised proposal to the BEST committee, which has approved the marginal increase. "We will now inform Switch Mobility about it. Necessary documentation will be taken up and revised rates be implemented," said a senior BEST official.

Switch Mobility will now have to submit a fresh manufacturing and delivery schedule. Sources said the buses are expected to start arriving in batches towards the end of this year.

The supply of the buses had been stalled since December 2024 over technical and contractual issues.

The dispute was referred to the Attorney General for a legal opinion and subsequently examined by a technical committee, which recommended the revision in the per-km lease payment in line with a Central government notification. "There is a scope of having 5-7 open deck semi AC buses as well as the city is a good tourist attraction," said BEST chairperson Trushna Vishwasrao.

The return of the remaining buses will give BEST a significant boost to its electric fleet and add capacity on some of Mumbai's busiest routes, where passenger demand often outstrips available seating.

The electric double-deckers, which are fully air-conditioned and powered by electricity, have become a popular and recognisable feature of Mumbai's public transport network.

BMC to pool Lower Parel plots with SRA scheme

BMC to get PAP tenements free of cost; Congress leader Azmi terms proposal 'a loss-making deal'

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MUMBAI: The BMC is set to amalgamate some of its land in Lower Parel with an ongoing Slum Rehabilitation Authority (SRA) scheme, paving the way for their integrated redevelopment. The plots, located around N M Joshi Marg and Pandurang Budhkar Marg, will be clubbed with the Shri Sai Sunder Nagar Co-operative Housing Society Ltd SRA and other societies, along with several other plots in Lower Parel and Mahim.

The proposal was jointly submitted by developers Vrinda Enterprises Pvt Ltd and Skylark Buildcon Pvt Ltd and forwarded by the SRA to the municipal commissioner. It was tabled at the civic improvements committee and cleared on August 13.

The proposal is based on directions issued by the urban development department on July 3 last year, which introduced provisions under Regulation 33(10) of the Development Control and Promotion Rules (DCPR). These provisions allow schemes for construction of Project Affected Persons (PAP) tenements and amenities on built-up, vacant, reserved or designated plots owned by public authorities such as the BMC. Such plots can subsequently be amalgamated with an SRA scheme in the same administrative ward.

Under the proposal, the municipal plots will be developed at the permissible FSI, with the FSI required for existing or reserved municipal facilities being used for these, and the balance being utilised for PAP housing. The PAP tenements generated from the development will be handed over to the BMC free of cost.



The Shri Sai Sunder Nagar Cooperative Housing Society in Lower Parel, which is proposed to be amalgamated with BMC plots for integrated redevelopment.

The proposal covers a sizable cluster of plots, with the total area of the proposed amalgamated scheme estimated at 1,09,220.10 sq m. The document calculates the BMC-owned component at 25% of the total amalgamated area.

Several of the BMC plots are currently occupied by municipal facilities such as a municipal school, a municipal chowky, the G South Ward office and Shantabai Hule municipal market. One plot, reserved for a garden/playground, is partly occupied by slum-like structures.

The BMC has made it clear that the developer will have to reconstruct all these municipal facilities at the maximum permissible FSI under DCPR 2034 and hand them over to the civic body free of cost. The reserved garden/playground will also have to be developed and handed over to the BMC. The civic body has also stipulated that during the redevelopment period, the developer will have to make alternative arrangements at its own cost for all these facilities.

The construction cost of these municipal facilities is estimated at around ₹14.27 crore. In addition, the BMC is expected to

receive a 25 per cent land premium of approximately ₹35.13 crore. The municipal housing component is estimated to translate into approximately 189 PAP tenements. The proposal says that if the SRA permits an FSI of more than 4.0, the additional potential could be used for constructing more PAP tenements. If these additional homes are handed over to the BMC free of cost, the civic body will have no objection to granting the corresponding incentive FSI to the developer.

The proposal also seeks to ensure that the BMC retains ownership of its land. In particular, the civic body has stipulated that the plots currently housing the school, chowky and ward office, together measuring approximately 8,994.05 sq m, will continue to remain BMC property. The BMC has also proposed that the residents of the cooperative housing society to be created through redevelopment be granted a lease over the municipal land for an initial period of 30 years. Any subsequent renewal will be subject to BMC's discretion and the prevailing policy at that time.

Another significant condition relates to the land premium. The

developer will be required to pay the applicable 25 per cent land premium, while the SRA will have to transfer the amount collected to the BMC within 30 days.

Congress leader opposes

Ashraf Azmi, Congress group leader in the BMC, who had opposed the proposal, said that it had been "managed" in a particular manner to facilitate the deal for the civic body's favoured developers. "What is the BMC getting by giving away this prime land?" he asked. "The SRA builder will benefit by creating a sale component on the site."

Azmi added that the ownership of the land must remain with the BMC. "Once the land is handed over to the SRA, it will be gone permanently," he said. "Our contention is that this is a loss-making deal for the BMC, and there is a huge disparity between what the BMC is going to receive and the value of the land it is handing over to the SRA. The BMC should get land equivalent in value to what it is giving away."

A senior SRA official said, "We will do planning as per the urban development department's directions."

Mother-in-law paid former maid ₹3 lakh to kill 35-year-old woman in Ghatkopar

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MUMBAI: The Pant Nagar police probing the murder of 35-year-old Sapna Ganji in Ghatkopar East found that her mother-in-law allegedly hired a former domestic help for ₹3 lakh to kill her, with the maid roping in her husband, daughter and son to carry out the plan, police said. All five accused have been arrested, police said.

The victim, Sapna Ganji, lived with her 10-year-old son, Shivansh, at Triveni Building in Laxmi Nagar, Ghatkopar East. Her husband, Pramod works with an information technology company in Dubai, while Sapna had returned to India in June with their son.

The murder initially came to light after Sapna's mother-in-law, Dhanalaxmi Ganji, allegedly told her parents that Sapna had died after falling in the bathroom. Sapna's father,

VICTIM'S FATHER ALLEGED THAT THE ACCUSED HELD A GRUDGE AS HIS DAUGHTER HAD FILED A HARASSMENT CASE AGAINST HER IN-LAWS IN 2024

Rajendra Vallal, a tailor from Nallasopara, reached Rajawadi Hospital and noticed several injuries on his daughter's body, prompting him to suspect foul play.

Rajendra told police that Dhanalaxmi held a grudge against Sapna after she had filed a harassment case against her in-laws in 2024. Following his complaint, the Pant Nagar police registered a case under relevant sections of the BNS and arrested Dhanalaxmi. A post-mortem examination later con-

firmed that Sapna had died of strangulation.

Investigators later examined CCTV footage and found that several people had entered the building around 4.30pm on Sunday.

"During questioning, Dhanalaxmi admitted to hatching a plan to kill her daughter-in-law," a police officer said.

Dhanalaxmi told investigators that Sapna was a habitual drinker and that the family suspected her of having an affair.

Police said Dhanalaxmi subsequently contacted her former domestic help, Mangala Jadhav, 45, and offered her ₹3 lakh to help kill Sapna. Mangala allegedly then brought her husband Suresh Jadhav, 46, daughter Shivani Jadhav, 21, and son Sajjan Jadhav, 19, into the plan.

The four allegedly entered Sapna's apartment when she was drinking. The accused allegedly then used a dupatta to strangle Sapna.

NO TOBACCO STALLS IN EDU CAMPUSES: CM

MUMBAI: Preventing the youth from getting addicted to tobacco is far more effective than taking corrective measures, said chief minister Devendra Fadnavis, who has directed every school and college campus to be free of tobacco stalls and unauthorised kiosks. He said principals and headmasters must declare their campuses drug-free.

In a review meeting of the Drug-Free Maharashtra initiative on Wednesday, the chief minister said efforts should focus on preventing the factors that push young people towards substance abuse. Directing that de-addiction centres be established in every government hospital to help young people trapped in addiction, Fadnavis said they must be made operational in all government medical colleges. He further directed that measures should be taken to control the factors responsible for addiction. **HTC**

State to lift 16-year ban on govt land allotment to hsg societies

Faisal Malik

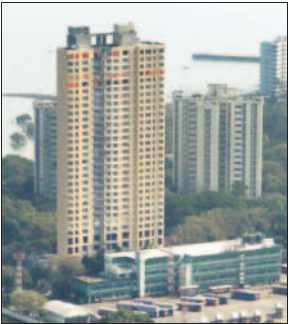
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MUMBAI: Nearly 16 years after the Adarsh Housing Society scam surfaced, the Maharashtra government has decided to lift the ban on allotting government land to cooperative housing societies by introducing a fresh policy that replaces the lottery system with direct auctions.

Under the proposed policy, government land will be auctioned to housing societies through a technical and financial bidding process, with the society offering the highest bid being selected. The base price will be fixed at 2.5% of the land's market value in Mumbai city and its suburbs, and at 5% elsewhere in the state.

The draft policy was approved by state revenue minister Chandrashekhar Bawankule on Wednesday. It will now be placed before chief minister Devendra Fadnavis for final approval.

The state government had previously allotted land to cooperative housing societies under



The Adarsh Housing Society scam came to light in 2010. **HT**

government resolutions issued on July 9, 1999, and May 25, 2007.

However, the allotment was halted following the Adarsh Housing Society scam in 2010, which rocked the then Congress-NCP government. The controversy eventually led to the resignation of then chief minister Ashok Chavan, who was accused of facilitating the allotment of flats to close relatives in return for favours.

In March 2014, the Bombay High Court also struck down

government schemes for allotting houses to needy persons under the chief minister's discretionary quota, terming them "illegal, unfair and irrational". The court, however, allowed the state government to frame a fresh policy based on transparency and fairness but nothing materialised then.

Bawankule said the revised policy has been drafted in view of a petition in the high court filed by the Sanjay Gandhi Cooperative Housing Society in Kolhapur, as well as observations made by the Supreme Court on November 25, 2024.

"Under the new policy, government land will no longer be allotted through the earlier lottery system. Instead, allotments will be made through a direct auction process," the revenue minister said. District collectors will prepare lists of available government plots, following which auctions will be conducted through technical and financial bids after issuing public advertisements, he added.

The new policy will also end the practice of transferring gov-

ernment land on an ownership basis. Instead, plots will be granted on a 30-year lease, after which they will become eligible for conversion to Occupancy Class-I status, effectively making them freehold.

To ensure representation of different sections of society, the government has proposed category-wise reservations. General category societies will get 40% of the plots, while 15% will be reserved for housing societies of state government, local body and government undertaking employees.

Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST) and Nomadic Tribes (NT) will have a 10% quota, while writers, artists, sportspersons and journalists will also get 10%. Freedom fighters and their heirs, organisations of persons with disabilities and Economically Weaker Sections (EWS) will have a 5% quota as will serving and former MPs and MLAs.

Another 5% each will be reserved for central government employees and serving or former armed forces personnel.

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J'khand students pause stir for 60 days after exams cancelled

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RANCHI: The job aspirants and student unions agitating against the alleged irregularities in Jharkhand recruitment exams for nearly a month in Ranchi on Wednesday announced a 60-day suspension of their indefinite sit-in after the state government conceded to almost all of their key demands.

The decision was announced by student representatives at a press conference at the Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium grounds, calling it a strategic pause to see if the government fulfils its promises. They further warned of resuming the protest if the government falls short in implementing them.

The development comes two days after chief minister Hemant Soren-led state government announced the cancellation of 22 exams and ordered a probe into 23 others that were being conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC) and TSR Data Processing Private Limited (TDPL), an out-sourced agency, since 2014.

The probe was ordered based on findings from the ongoing probe by the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) of the state police into alleged irregularities, including paper leaks, bribery, and OMR sheet manipulations, in these exams.

The administration also expanded the ongoing CID probe to review all public recruitment exams held since 2014 and established a dedicated reform committee under a senior IAS officer to overhaul the examination infrastructure.

Talking to reporters, students' representative Kunal Singh said: "We are not going to end the agitation, but we have unanimously decided on a postponement to give the government an opportunity to honour its words given to students."

Singh further raised a demand for the government's legal support.



Protesters celebrate after the cancellation of recruitment exams on Wednesday.

"We also expect the government to support us in the court. Government should file a caveat and put its argument in favour of its cabinet decision properly," Singh said. "We also expect transparency in investigation the government has promised. If this does not happen, we will resume our protest."

While student leaders, including Devendra Nath Mahto and two others, broke their fasts after 16 days following the government's notifications, the student bodies emphasised that their ultimate demand for a probe into irregularities by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) remains on the table.

State minister Irfan Ansari reiterated that the government stood with the youth. "A consensus has been reached... the government is with the youth..." he told reporters.

Meanwhile, the students leaders also took out "Abhar Yatra" (thanksgiving) procession for all the students and guardians who supported their movement to bring reforms and overhaul in the system. The 'yatra' that started from Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium, the protest site, culminated at the Albert Ekka Chowk in the state capital.

"This is the result of a 16-day hunger strike and 24 days of 'satyagraha'. The 'satyagraha' started on August 24, and the hunger strike on August 2," student leader Mahto said, while also expressing his gratitude to chief minister Soren for addressing their concerns.

NTA tightens process for hiring of subject experts

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NEW DELHI: The National Testing Agency (NTA) is strengthening its process for hiring subject experts to prepare question papers for forthcoming national-level examinations. Those teachers who want to serve as subject experts will have to submit their educational and employment records, identity documents, conflict-of-interest and confidentiality declarations, and a No Objection Certificate (NOC) from their current employer, according to an internal NTA communication reviewed by HT.

The new requirements come a day after the testing body on Tuesday removed 600 subject experts as part of a rehaul of its examination system following the Union education ministry's directions to "fix accountability", conduct a thorough audit of its examination processes and submit a report on corrective action within 30 days—all reactions to a series of controversies involving NTA including paper leaks and incorrect questions in papers.

According to the circular, NTA has prescribed a four-stage process for empanelling of subject experts. In the first stage, it will verify the completeness of applications, qualifications, experience and supporting documents including Aadhar card, PAN card and the NOC.

The second stage will involve subject-matter evaluation, with NTA assessing academic standing, research record, previous experience in setting test papers, and depth of expertise. "The evaluation will be conducted by subject expert committees constituted by NTA," the agency said in its note.

Shortlisted candidates will then undergo "comprehensive background verification" in the

HC refuses to entertain plea to scrap NTA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Wednesday refused to entertain a petition of two NEET aspirants seeking the scrapping of the National Testing Agency (NTA) and an investigation into alleged discrepancies in the NEET-UG re-examination, observing that the reliefs they sought were personal in nature and did not qualify as PIL.

"From a perusal of the prayer clause, we find that it is a mixed bunch of prayers made seeking relief in respect of the petitioner and also all candidates who appeared in re-NEET exams. Such a writ petition with the mixture of prayers, in our opinion, cannot be entertained," a bench of chief justice DK Upadhyaya and justice Tejas Karia said in its order. **SHRUTI KAKKAR**

third stage, covering academic credentials, employment history, integrity declarations and conflict-of-interest disclosures, among other checks.

In the fourth stage, those selected following stage three will be formally empanelled for specific subject domains, levels and types of work. The empanelment will be valid for three years, subject to "satisfactory performance and continued integrity," according to the communication. "Empanelment may be terminated earlier in case of breach of

any term, on reasonable grounds, with appropriate notice," the NTA note said.

NTA and the Union education ministry did not respond to HT's queries.

NTA conducts 10 major national-level entrance examinations in multiple shifts throughout the year, and the papers for these are set by the empanelled subject experts, who are paid between ₹35,000 to ₹40,000 in a year. Their involvement lasts 7 to 15 days depending upon their roles in preparing question papers and examinations.

Paper setters have emerged the weak link in NTA's efforts to make its papers leak-proof. IIT Madras director V Kamakoti, part of the Nandan Nikelani headed committee that is looking at reforming the testing process, recently said that the integrity of paper setters is critical. However, the requirement of an NOC in the list of documents from serving faculty has raised concerns among some existing NTA subject experts.

One said the requirement could make the process vulnerable to institutional pressures. "Institute heads will give NOC to faculties who adhere to their ideologies. This is problematic."

Another, a faculty member in a state university said this could mean people not fit to become subject matter experts end up becoming that.

This person, who asked not to be named, also said the new process seemed cumbersome.

Previously, "NTA used to send mails to us showing its interest in hiring us as a subject expert on contractual basis. We were asked to just submit our CV and a declaration that our wards and relatives' children are not sitting examinations."

NTA has not publicly disclosed the total number of subject experts in its existing pool.

Congress to intensify its student outreach across 800 cities



(From left) Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge, Rahul Gandhi and KC Venugopal during the CWC meeting. HT PHOTO

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NEW DELHI: The Congress Working Committee (CWC) said on Wednesday it would double down on the party's outreach to students by extending Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi's "Chhatron ki Goonj" programme to 800 towns, launch a grassroots agitation against alleged donation theft at the Ram Mandir and resolved not to sing the full version of the national song Vande Mataram at party events.

Following a four-hour-long meeting of the party's apex top executive body, Congress general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal said paper leaks and students' issues are the party's top priority. HT on August 18 had reported that CWC would chart an expansion plan of Chhatron ki Goonj (Voice of Students).

The move comes in the backdrop of the Congress launching an intense protest against the government in the recently concluded monsoon session of Parliament over the use of force against protesting students in New Delhi on July 20. The students' protest, headed by Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), came in the wake of allegations of irregularities, including paper leak, in the NEET-UG 2026.

"Number one issue is paper leak. The agitation of students and the way in which the government reacted to it made it clear that the government was on the back foot. We have decided that LoP Rahul Gandhi's Chhatron ki Goonj and his direct involvement of agitation, especially the surgical strike on PM's house, created a big impact. The CWC decided that we will continue Chhatron ki Goonj in around 800 cities small and medium cities. Rahul Gandhi will attend some of these programmes," Venugopal said.

During the meeting, Rahul Gandhi urged party leaders to meet students and common people, while party chief Mallikarjun Kharge asked Congress-led state governments to consult experts to prepare a blueprint for education and exam reforms in their respective states.

Venugopal also announced the

party's decision to sing the abridged version of the national song Vande Mataram—and not the full version as stipulated by the government for official functions—citing the decision of stalwarts such as Rabin Dranath Tagore, Sardar Patel, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose, Jawaharlal Nehru and others in 1937. The decision also comes amid row over the alleged conduct of senior leaders Sonia and Rahul Gandhi during the rendition of the national song at the Congress headquarters on the Independence Day. Defending the decision to sing only the first two stanzas of the national song, Venugopal said: "Vande Mataram and the National Anthem are emotional issues for us. But it is a political issue for the BJP." In the meeting, three senior leaders Anand Sharma, Digvijaya Singh and Tariq Anwar said there would be no compromise on the party's stance on Vande Mataram issue. The Centre issued a circular in February this year to sing all six stanzas of the national song in official programmes.

Kharge said youth is "the primary focus" of the party's "collective concern" and pitched for a "comprehensive, and time-bound 'Education-to-Employment Roadmap' for the youth," pitching for a policy shift to benefit Gen Z.

Channi skips meeting

Meanwhile, former Punjab chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi was conspicuous by his absence during the CWC meeting, where the preparations for the upcoming Punjab assembly polls also featured in discussion.

A senior Punjab Congress leader said Channi was scheduled to sit for an examination at Panjab University on Thursday. "We will wish him well. May he complete his PhD and become a doctor," Congress MP Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa said.

Channi's absence comes against the backdrop of a bitter internal battle within the Punjab Congress ahead of the assembly polls. When asked about Channi not attending the CWC meeting due to his exam, Baghel said: "Is what he saying wrong? Then what is the news here?"

SC seeks details of Nilekani task force's mandate

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court bench hearing the NEET paper leak case on Wednesday sought clarity on the role of the Nandan Nilekani-led task force, which was constituted last month to overhaul India's examination system.

While the K Radhakrishnan committee (set up in 2024) had focused substantially on NEET and strengthening the NTA, the

Nilekani panel has a wider mandate covering the country's examination ecosystem and the statutory framework of the NTA. Its recommendations are aimed at making the examination system "robust, secure, transparent, trustworthy and future-ready".

The court asked the Centre to place on record whether the Nilekani panel had modified or the recommendations of the Radhakrishnan committee and the stage of implementation of both sets of recommendations.

WRONG TO SAY CHINA INTRUDED 60KM INTO INDIAN TERRITORY: RIJJU



Kiren Rijju

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NEW DELHI: Parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijju on Wednesday said people living on either side of the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in some areas of Arunachal Pradesh have differing perceptions of the boundary because it is not demarcated, leading to some confusion.

He trashed reports suggesting that China had intruded 60km into Indian territory.

"It is not like they (China) came and captured our village. That is not the case. On certain land, they have cast an eye because there is no demarcation. Our people believe that our land extends further ahead, while the villages situated on the China side, including Tibetan and local people, claim that their land extends deep inside here. So, there is confusion," he said in an interview to news agency IANS.

The comments came days after the Ministry of External Affairs said that the state of border affairs has ramifications for overall India-China ties, adding that the two sides have agreed to use existing diplomatic and military mechanisms to "avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation" along the border.

On August 11, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal made the remarks while responding to a question on the military situation between India and China in the Arunachal Pradesh sector and whether recent reports of a standoff had been taken up diplomatically with China. There is no clarity on the current status of the standoff in the Arunachal Pradesh sector, though people familiar with the situation earlier said that the problems first emerged in the remote Taksin area in early July.

Gor says J&K an imp part of India

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SRINAGAR: US ambassador Sergio Gor on Wednesday described Jammu and Kashmir as an "important part of India" during a visit to Srinagar, prompting Pakistan to summon the senior-most American diplomat in Islamabad to register a protest.

Gor, the first US ambassador to travel to Jammu and Kashmir in six years, made the remarks after a meeting with chief minister Omar Abdullah. He also indicated that the US could look into downgrading a travel advisory for Kashmir in view of the improvement in the situation in the region.

"This is an important part of India and so I am here visiting for the first time. It is an incredibly beautiful place and I'm thrilled to be here, thrilled to see this place," Gor said while speaking to the local media along with Abdullah.

Gor, who is also the US special envoy for South and Central



J&K CM Omar Abdullah during a meeting with US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor in Srinagar on Wednesday. X/OMARABDULLAH

Asia, noted that the US has a practice of reviewing travel warnings that it issues for its citizens and said: "I cannot make any big announcements here today but it is something we are going to look at."

Both the Central and Jammu and Kashmir governments "have made some incredible steps in keeping this area safer", he said. "We will be looking at if

the travel warning that is recommended by the US is something that should be downgraded because as I said earlier this is a beautiful area. I think a lot of Americans would enjoy coming here and seeing the beauty," Gor said.

If the US state department downgrades the threat level, it could turn out to be a major boost for the tourism sector in Kashmir. Tourism accounts for 7% of the state GDP.

Hours later, Pakistan's foreign ministry summoned the US charge d'affaires in Islamabad, Natalie Baker, and served her a "strong demarche" on Gor's visit to Kashmir and his "incorrect statement regarding the status of the disputed territory".

A statement from Pakistan's foreign ministry described Gor's remarks on the status of Jammu and Kashmir as "factually incorrect".

"Pakistan strongly condemned and categorically rejected the characterisation of Jammu and Kashmir as a 'part of India'," the statement said.

(With inputs from Mir Ehsan in Srinagar)

NCERT reconstitutes textbook team for classes 11, 12 pol science

Press Trust of India

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NEW DELHI: The National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) has reconstituted the Textbook Development Team for class 11 and 12 political science with a mandate to integrate "cultural rootedness", Indian knowledge systems and inclusion, with at least four of the members having direct or indirect links with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS).

The team has been asked to develop the class 11 textbook by November and the class 12 book by July next year.

The textbook team will be led by academic and political analyst Sandeep Shastri, vice president of Karnataka-based deemed university Nitte.

Among the members of the textbook development team are at least four academics and edu-

THE NEW TEAM INCLUDES AT LEAST 4 MEMBERS HAVING DIRECT OR INDIRECT LINKS WITH THE RSS

cationists with direct or indirect documented backgrounds in the RSS-affiliated Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). Yadunath Deshpande, now a senior consultant with the ministry of education, has a long-standing organisational background in the ABVP.

The organisation's own records identify him as its joint state organising secretary for Maharashtra in the past. He subsequently served as an organising secretary in the ABVP's Mumbai-Konkan structure. His LinkedIn profile describes him

as political consultant for BJP.

Prashant Divekar has a long-standing association with Pune-based Jnana Prabodhini, an RSS-affiliated institution. It was founded in 1962 by Vinayak Vishwanath, an RSS member and pracharak. In his profile on the National Council for Teacher Education's National Mission for Mentoring portal, Divekar describes his approach as being "rooted in Bhartiya educational philosophy" and says he has contributed to the National Curriculum Framework. Vandana Mishra, professor at JNU's Centre for Political Studies, is a former national secretary of the ABVP. Ravi Rameshchandra Shukla, Associate Professor at JNU, has been a member of the editorial board of the Indian Journal of Democratic Governance, published by the Indian Institute of Democratic Leadership-Rambhau Mhalgi Prabodhini, an RSS affiliate.

{ NEET EXAM LEAK }

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government on Wednesday withdrew a controversial circular directing that students be prevented from participating in protests of Leftist groups and parties, including the online collective Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), after it sparked a row.

In the circular on Saturday, the commissioner of collegiate education directed college principals to initiate interdepartmental coordination and integrated action with the school education and higher education departments, police, and district administrations to prevent students from participating in protests. It asked for immediate details of the action taken. On Wednesday, the directorate said the circular has been withdrawn.

The Students' Federation of



C Joseph Vijay

India (SFI), the Communist Party of India (Marxist)'s student wing, called the withdrawal of the circular a victory for democratic rights of students. "This victory is not just a win for SFI's protest. It is a democratic victory demonstrating that if students unite and raise their voice for their rights, they can question the government," said SFI's Tamil Nadu chief C Mrithula. "We will not let students' voices be suppressed. We will continue to fight for democratic rights."

Vijay: All MLAs to get cars, ₹1 lakh allowance

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay announced on Wednesday that his government will provide every legislator in the state an official vehicle and a monthly ₹1-lakh allowance for fuel, maintenance and driver expenses, saying that the number of first-time MLAs who don't have their own vehicles has significantly increased. As many as 110 MLAs are first-timers. He said the decision was made to help the MLAs take up constituency development work. Assembly Speaker JCD Prabhakar said the scheme has been announced for all MLAs.

UNION MINS GET REPORT CARD ON THEIR SOCIAL MEDIA OUTPUT

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NEW DELHI: Members of the Union Council of Ministers received an analysis of their performance on four major social media platforms during Wednesday's cabinet meeting chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and were also given instructions to expand their footprint across networks and scale up outreach, said people aware of the matter.

To bolster the government's outreach on the ground, the PM is also learnt to have told the ministers to visit public schools and universities for "freewheeling chats" with students. Union ministers Pralhad Joshi and Mansukh Mandaviya will coordinate the outreach which is aimed at Gen Z and Gen Alpha, said people quoted above.

The analysis evaluated their posts and interactions on Facebook, LinkedIn, X and Instagram between May and August 15, said one person. Wednesday's instruction comes amid efforts by the Centre to counter the anger and criticism it faced on social media during and after recent protests over paper leaks led by the CJP. The PM has been vocal about using social media platforms to disseminate government plans and programmes, to forge a direct link between the electorate and elected representatives and to shape the narrative. In recent meetings with the Bharatiya Janata Party-led National Democratic Alliance lawmakers, he had reiterated the need to improve social media outreach. "This was like a SWOT analysis of their presence on four platforms, and how they compared to some popular leaders and public figures... no rankings were publicly disclosed," said the person quoted above.

The person said the engagement was assessed based on daily posts and the traction they received.

PUNE RESIDENT HELD FOR RAPING, KILLING 10-YR-OLD

Shrinivas Deshpande

letters@hindustantimes.com

PUNE: A 10-year-old girl was allegedly raped and murdered in Maharashtra's Pune district, police said on Wednesday, adding that a 25-year-old man has been arrested over the case.

The incident took place around 2 pm on Tuesday in Pimpalwadi village of Junnar tehsil, police said. The girl's parents, who are agricultural labourers, were away for work. When she was not found at home, police were informed around 6-7 pm.

According to police, the accused, a farm labourer and neighbour of the victim's family, allegedly lured the girl on the pretext of taking her to eat guava and led her about 1 to 1.5 km away from the village. Pune rural superintendent of police Sandip Singh Gill said, "He allegedly took her to an agricultural field, raped her, and strangled her to death."

The accused, a Class 4 dropout, has no previous criminal record, police said.

SDPO Dhananjay Patil said, "During interrogation, he confessed and led the police team to the spot where the girl's body was found." The post-mortem examination is underway.

5 Bangladeshis among nine dead in Kolkata hotel blaze

Tanmay Chatterjee and Joydeep Thakur

letters@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: Five Bangladeshi nationals, including a two-year-and-eight-month-old boy, a Jharkhand resident and a Siliguri resident were among nine people killed after a fire broke out at a hotel on the second floor of a five-storey building on Mirza Ghalib Street in central Kolkata around 2am on Wednesday, city police and Kolkata's Bangladesh deputy high commission officials said.

A five-member special investigation team (SIT) has been formed to probe the fire and alleged lapses in fire-safety measures.

The blaze broke out at Shikha Inn, one of several small hotels operating from the building at 15H Mirza Ghalib Street. Four fire tenders reached the spot and brought the fire under control in about two hours, officials said.

The building is around 50 metres from the West Bengal Fire and Emergency Services head-quarters and within about 500 metres of the Kolkata Municipal Corporation.

Chief minister Svendun Adhikari said the fire highlighted alleged failures in enforcing safety norms. "This tragedy is a grim reminder of the legacy of negligence left behind by the previous regime," he wrote on X.

"A five-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) has been formed to conduct a comprehensive inquiry into this incident," the CM added.

The five Bangladeshi victims were identified as Debashish Dutta, 39, a journalist from Kushtia; his wife Afsana Sharmin, 27; their two-year-and-eight-month-old son Swarnashish Dutta; Afsana's father Md Akram Ali, 74; and Ahmed Babu (37) from Dhaka, deputy high commissioner of Bangladesh in Kolkata, Mohammad Khaled said.

Bangladesh deputy high commission officials said Dutta had travelled to Bengaluru for medical treatment. The family checked into the Kolkata hotel on Tuesday after returning from Bengaluru and was scheduled to return to Bangladesh on Wednesday.

"Two bodies remained uniden-

tified till Wednesday evening," deputy commissioner of police (central division) Praween Prakash said.

Firefighters said thick smoke quickly engulfed the third floor cutting off access to the only staircase. "We rescued more than 60 persons who were unhurt but at least nine people were found unconscious. They were rushed to hospital," a fire brigade officer said.

The officer added, "We suspect a short circuit caused the fire. We can confirm only after the forensic analysis."

Md Ujjwal, a 49-year-old businessman from Khulna in Bangladesh staying at Hotel Adrita on the same floor, said, "With the fire blocking access to the only staircase, I locked myself inside the room and broke a plank near the air-conditioner to allow fresh air in. About an hour later, the fire brigade rescued me," he said.

Amirul Hossain, a guest at the hotel, said, "There was no fire alarm, no fire exit, and no fire-fighting system. It was a miracle that we managed to escape."

State fire and emergency services minister Kaushik Chowdhury said, "In each of the floors there were at least four to five hotels. The rooms in these hotels were small and most of them didn't have any window or ventilation. There was hardly any fire-alarm or fire-fighting system."

Locals said the buildings at 15F, 15G and 15H Mirza Ghalib Street were originally residential but were gradually converted into commercial spaces.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi condoled the deaths and shared a post on X: "Extremely pained to learn about the loss of lives due to a fire mishap in Kolkata. My condolences to those who have lost their loved ones in this tragedy."

Minister Agnimitra Paul, who visited the site, said, "How were these hotels running? How did they get the trade license, fire license and power connection?" Paul told the reporters.

Former minister Firhad Hakim accused the government of politicising the tragedy. "This is politics. During our tenure so many people died in devastating fires in Kolkata but we never blamed the erstwhile Left Front government."

Timeline of the incident

1:30 am-2 am: Fire breaks out at Shikha Inn on the second floor of a five-storey building on Mirza Ghalib Street

2 am: Guests wake up to screams and shouts as thick smoke engulfs the third floor, cutting off access to the only staircase

2:10 am: Four fire tenders reach the spot and begin rescue operations. Firefighters rescue more than 60 people over the next two hours.

4 am: Fire is brought under control

4 pm: Nine people are confirmed dead, including five Bangladeshi



nationals, a Jharkhand resident and a Siliguri resident. Two bodies remain unidentified

5 pm: A five-member SIT is formed to probe the fire and alleged lapses in fire-safety arrangements

B'deshi journalist, kin had come for treatment

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: A Bangladeshi journalist, his wife, their young son and his father-in-law were among nine people killed in the fire at Hotel Shikha Inn in central Kolkata on Wednesday. The family had come to India for medical treatment and was scheduled to return to Bangladesh the same day.

At Arupara in Bangladesh's Kushtia, Swapna Dutta, 62, has been inconsolable since learning that her son Debashish Dutta, 39, daughter-in-law Afsana Sharmin, 27, and two-year-and-eight-month-old grandson Swarnashish Dutta, had died. Their six-year-old daughter had stayed back with her grandparents in Kushtia.

"I last spoke to my son around 9:45 pm on Tuesday. They had done some shopping and my son said they would be back home on Wednesday. How will I raise my granddaughters now?" Swapna told reporters.

The family, including Sharmin's father Akram Ali, 74, travelled to India on August 3 for treatment. After spending two days in Kolkata, they went to Bengaluru for Sharmin's and Sharmashish's

treatment and returned to Kolkata before checking into Shikha Inn on Monday.

The Bangladesh deputy high commission said five of the nine victims were Bangladeshi nationals. Four were from Kushtia and belonged to the same family. The fifth victim was Babu Ahmed, 37, from Aminabazar in Dhaka.

The New Market area, including Mirza Ghalib Street, Marquis Street and Sudder Street, has several budget hotels popular with Bangladeshi visitors. Room tariffs can start at around ₹500.

"I am a tourist from Dhaka... This area offers cheap hotels and is also centrally located. The buses which come from Dhaka stops at Esplanade, which is close by. Also, the shopping area is nearby. Hence this New Market area is a favourite spot for us Bangladeshis who come to Kolkata," said Md Mushfiqur Rahaman, 42, from Khulna.

India resumed normal tourist visa services for Bangladeshis in June 2024 after restrictions imposed following political unrest in 2024. A total of 1.6 million Bangladeshis visited India in 2023, with 60% travelling for tourism and 30% for medical treatment.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

SC-NTA

submitted its recommendations in October 2024. HT reported in late July that only 57 of the 101 recommendations of the Radhakrishnan committee were fully recommended and another 10 partially. One of the most significant of these recommendations, the restructuring of NTA, was implemented only in the third week of July, following the 2026 NEET paper leak, which forced a retest. The controversy eventually claimed the head of then education minister Dhamendra Pradhan.

The court directed the secre-

tary concerned to file an affidavit within three weeks, detailing the steps taken to implement the Radhakrishnan committee's recommendations as reflected and nuanced by the Nilekani committee, along with indicative timelines.

The order said its concern was the "institutionalisation of National Testing Agency with all necessary infrastructure, manpower and other technological capabilities."

The court's intervention came as the Centre explained in detail the elaborate security measures currently employed by the NTA to prevent question-paper leaks, including multiple layers of question-paper selec-

tion, sealed transportation, GPS tracking, CCTV surveillance, police escort and one-time-use boxes that have to be physically broken open before the examination.

But the bench said such measures were already part of the examination systems examined by the Radhakrishnan committee and the real concern was whether these safeguards

could survive changes in personnel and evolve into a permanent institutional processes.

"All this was already under the purview of the Radhakrishnan committee," observed the bench, saying the court had gone through the systems being developed. It added that the committee had correctly identified the problem as systemic, requiring institutionalisation.

U.T. ADMINISTRATION OF DADRA & NAGAR HAVELI AND DAMAN & DIU
P.W.D. CIVIL DIVISION NO.11 (DP)
NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Rewinding and repairing of Motors at various site in DNH area for the year 2025-26 (8th Call)



For details please scan
dntenders.gov.in
sc:rdhnh@gmail.com
02602642949

EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, PWD CIVIL DIV NO.11 (DP), DNH, SILVASSA
No.5-21(DNH/DP/2026/ DL18/08/2026
No.1P/DMN/2/5/2026-27/441 Silvassa Dt.19/08/2026

PUNJAB STATE WAREHOUSING CORPORATION, CHANDIGARH
SCO 74-75, BANK SQUARE, SECTOR-17B, CHANDIGARH
E-mail: ctpswc@punjab.gov.in
NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER
TENDER NO. : PSWC/CTO/2026-27/06

Punjab State Warehousing Corporation invites online bids for the Integration of Anna Darpan Portal (FCI) with Electronic Weighbridges Installed at PSWC Owned Warehouses across all Districts of Punjab State Warehousing Corporation.

Closing date and time : 04.09.2026 at 3.00 pm

For details log on to : <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>

Note: Any addendum(s)/Corrigendum(s) to the Tender Notice shall be published on the above website only.

RO No. 100412/2026/27/14326

Managing Director

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER
For and on behalf of the President of India, the Sr. Divisional Engineer/General Manager/Kharagpur-721301 invites e-tenders for the following work before 12:00 Hrs. on the date mentioned against items : **SI. No.; E-Tender Tender No.; Description of work; Tender Value; Bid Security/ E.M.D. respectively :** (1); 114-ELG-G-KGP-26-27-22, dtd. 17.08.2026; Electrical work for Segregation of Power Supply along with Improvement of Electrical Safety in Station Platforms under Sr.DEE(G)/KGP as Phase-2; ₹ 7,31,16,700.33; ₹ 14,62,300.00; **Date of Opening :** 02/09/2026 (for SI No. 1 & 2); **Cost of Tender Document :** Nil (for SI No. 1 & 2); **Completion Period :** 12 months for Srt. No. (1) & 18 months for Srt. No. (2) from the date of issue of Letter of Acceptance; **Date of Submission:** up to 12:00 Hrs. of 02/09/2026; Interested Tenderers may visit website www.irops.gov.in for full details, description and specification of the tender and submit their bids online. In no case manual tender for this work will be accepted. **Note:** Prospective bidders may regularly visit www.irops.gov.in to participate in all tenders. (PR-637)

WESTERN RAILWAY RATLAM DIVISION TENDER NOTICE
The Divisional Railway Manager (Electrical/Power) Ratlam invited "Open Tender" through e-tender on website www.irops.gov.in the details are as under: **Sr. No. 1 : E-tender No. : EL-2025-26-26R2 Name of Work :** Ratlam Division: Ratlam & Indore - Provision of 06 Escalators at Platform no 04 and platform no 07 of Ratlam station and 01 no. of Escalator in circulating area of PF-05/06 at Indore station. (Electrical + Civil) **Approx. Value :** Rs.7,40,59,417.39 **Earnest Money to be deposited:** Rs. 14,81,200.00 **Completion Period :** 12 Months **Date of uploading website :** 14/08/2026 **Date of opening Tender :** 08/09/2026. Details tender notice, eligibility criteria and terms and conditions are available at Website www.irops.gov.in cost of tender form is NIL. 49642/1
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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

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OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
P.W.D. CIRCLE DAUSA
क्रमांक:- फा/2026-27/डी- 2602-16 दिनांक: 12-08-2026

Notice Inviting Bid
10/2026-27
Bids for Nit No 10/2026-27, Nos 03 Atal Pragat Path Road Works are invited from interested bidders upto Date **27.08.2026 Time 06.00 P.M.** Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state and departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is **Rs. 518.01 Lacs**
NIB Code: PWD2627A2397
UBN No.: PWD2627WSOB10593
NIB Code: PWD2627A2398
UBN No.: PWD2627WSOB10594
UBN No.: PWD2627WSOB10595

अधीक्षण अभियन्ता
सा.नि.वि. वृत्त दौसा

DIPR/C/15321/2026

U.T. ADMINISTRATION OF DADRA & NAGAR HAVELI AND DAMAN & DIU
Public Works Department, Daman
NOTICE INVITING TENDER



For details please scan
<https://dntenders.gov.in>

Repairing of existing school building in change of roofing G.I.Sheet and painting work to Government Primary School, Moti Vankad in Bhimpore Group Gram Panchayat, Nani Daman. (2nd Call)

Tender Id No. : 2026 DAMAN 4926_1

Last date of download : 29/08/2026

Last date hard copy submission : 29/08/2026

Bid opening date : 29/08/2026

1/c Executive Engineer, P.W.D., District Panchayat, Moti Daman.
No.1P/DMN/2/5/2026-27/443 Date : 19.08.2026

PSPCL Punjab State Power Corporation Limited
(Regd. Office: PSEB Head Office, The Mall, Patiala)
Corporate Identification Number (CIN): U40109PB2010SGC033813
Website: www.pspcl.in
(Contact Number: 9646118754)

Tender Enquiry No. 358/HPS/ED-II/ASHP-150 Dated: 18.08.2026
Dy. CE/Hydel Projects, PSPCL, Shed A-3, Shakti Vihar, PSPCL, Patiala Invites E-Tender for: Special maintenance of 33.5 MW M/C No-3 at Nakkian Power House no 2 of ASHP Anandpur Sahib.

For detailed NIT & tender specification please refer to <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> from 21.08.2026 onwards.

NOTE: Corrigendum and Addendum, if any will be published online at <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>

RO No. 107912/2026/27/14424 C807/26

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग, वृत्त-भरतपुर
क्रमांक:- 1093 निविदा सूचना संख्या: 01/2026-27 दिनांक: 13.08.26

राजस्थान के राज्यपाल महोदय की ओर से सड़क घोषणा वर्ष 2026-27 के अन्तर्गत जिला भरतपुर में अटल प्रगति पथ निर्माण पथ निर्माण अन्वेष 05/10 वर्ष (बीटी/सीसी कार्य) के लिए उपयुक्त श्रेणी में सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग में पंजीकृत संवेदकों एवं राज्य सरकार/केन्द्रीय सरकार के अधिकृत संगठनों/केन्द्रीय लोक निर्माण विभाग/डाक एवं दूरसंचार विभाग/रेलवे इत्यादि में पंजीकृत संवेदकों, जो कि राजस्थान सरकार के विभिन्न सक्षम श्रेणी के संवेदकों के समकक्ष हों, से निर्धारित प्रथम में ई-प्रोक्चरमेंट प्रक्रिया हेतु ऑनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।

निविदा से सम्पर्कित समस्त विवरण वेबसाइट ["www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in"](http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in) एवं ["www.sppp.raj.nic.in"](http://www.sppp.raj.nic.in) पर देखा जा सकता है। दृष्टिक संवेदकों को अपने डिजिटल हस्ताक्षर के माध्यम से वेबसाइट ["www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in"](http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in) पर रजिस्टर करवाना आवश्यक है।

NIB NO. PWD2627A2279 & UBN NO. PWD2627WSRC10158, PWD2627WSRC10159, PWD2627WSRC10160

अधीक्षण अभियन्ता
सां.नि.वि. वृत्त-भरतपुर

DIPR/C/15153/2026

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, P.W.D. CIRCLE BANSWARA (RAJ.)
Address: Near Circuit House, Jaipur Road, Banswara (Raj.) 327001
Phone: 02962-241808
E-Mail: piu-banswara@rediffmail.com, sebahanswara.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in

क्रमांक: सी-662 निविदा सूचना संख्या: 01/2026-27 दिनांक: 13.08.2026

NIB: PWD2627A2351

Notice Inviting Bid (16/2026-27)

Bids for Remaining Work of Permanent Restoration Work of Flood Damaged in Banswara District, Remaining Work of Rehabilitation of various damaged BT Road & Construction of various Missing Link Road in Banswara District and Remaining Works of Approach Road Amariya Pada under UC PHO P.S. Bagidora (Risk and Cost) are invited from interested bidders from Dated 19.08.2026 9.30 am. to 08.09.2026 6.00 pm. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state. The approximate value of the procurement in **Rs. 643.43 Lacs.**

UBN:-
1-PWD2627WSOB10395
2-PWD2627WSOB10396
3-PWD2627WSOB10397
4-PWD2627WSOB10398
5-PWD2627WSOB10399

Sd/- (Anil Kumar Chhapra)
Superintending Engineer
P.W.D. Circle Banswara

DIPR/C/15134/2026

Office of the Additional Chief Engineer (Project) PHED, Ajmer
Qtr. No. II/2, PHED Colony, Vaishali Nagar, near RIICO Watch Factory,
Ph. No. 0145-2640265, Fax No. 0145-2640265,
Email: acepajm.phed@rajasthan.gov.in

S.No. F) ACE/Proj/AJR-UM (SEP-NGR)/ 2026-27/2996 Date: 14.08.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS FOR WORKS NIT No. 01/2026-27

Bid for "Bids for the "Operation and Maintenance of Main Pump Houses at Intake Nokha daiya and IPS Deshnok, 74MLD output capacity Water Treatment Plant at Nokha Daiya, including Electrical Mechanical and Instrumentation installations, switch yards, valves etc. and MS pipe line of 1200 mm diameter from Nokha Daiya Pump House to IPS Deshnok and IPS Deshnok Pumping Station to Nagaur (Approximate 131 Km total length) under the Nagaur Lift Project Phase-I, Package-I" is invited for interested bidders up to 07.09.2026. Other particulars of the Bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state.

"SAVE WATER - SAVE LIFE"

UBN No. : PHE2627WL0804282
NIB No. : PHE2627A2166

(Krishan Kumar Agarwal)
Additional Chief Engineer (Project)
PHED, Region, Ajmer

DIPR/C/14970/2026

OFFICE OF EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD DIVISION I SIKAR
No. 2658 Date: 11.08.2026

Notice Inviting Bid No. 12/2026-27
Bids for 25 (Twenty Five Nos.) Work are invited from interested bidders upto 06.00 PM dated 25.08.2026. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state; and PWD departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is **Rs. 348.87 Lac.**

NIB No.: PWD2627A2233
UBN No.: PWD2627WSOB09927, PWD2627WSOB09932, PWD2627WSOB09961, PWD2627WSOB09963, PWD2627WSOB09964, PWD2627WSOB09974, PWD2627WSOB09977, PWD2627WSOB09980, PWD2627WSOB10054 to PWD2627WSOB10063, PWD2627WSOB10065 to PWD2627WSOB10071

Sd/- Executive Engineer
PWD Dn. I Sikar

DIPR/C/14906/2026

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, PWD DIVISION SHAHPURA DISTT. BHIWLARA
File No:-1942-51 Date: 13.08.2026

Notice Inviting Bid No. 09/2026-27
Bids for Construction and Renewal of Various NP-ML Roads Under Budget Announcement 2026-27 are invited from interested bidders upto time 9.30 date 14.08.2026 to time 18.00 date 04.09.2026. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state; and PWD departmental website. The approximate values of the procurement is **Rs. 2104.37 Lacs**

NIB No. : PWD2627A2278
UBN No. : PWD2627WSOB10145, PWD2627WSOB10148, PWD2627WSOB10149, PWD2627WSOB10150, PWD2627WSOB10151, PWD2627WSOB10152, PWD2627WSOB10153, PWD2627WSOB10154, PWD2627WSOB10155, PWD2627WSOB10156, PWD2627WSOB10157

Sd/- (Anoop Singh Meena)
Executive Engineer
PWD Dn Shapura Distt. Bhiwara
Email: eeshapura.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in

DIPR/C/14961/2026

**Thane Municipal Corporation, Thane**
PUBLIC HEALTH DEPARTMENT
TENDER NOTICE

Online E-Tender is invited by Public Health Department period of five years for the comprehensive operation of Matoshree Gangubai Sambhaji Shinde Neonatal Intensive care unit (NICU) for newborns at Freedom Fighter Hakim Ajmal Khan Hospital, Mumbai. Details Tenders Notice & Tender Forms will be available on <https://mahatenders.gov.in> from Dt.20/08 /2026 to Dt.11/09/2026 at 11.00 am. Tender will be accepted on or before Dt.11/09/2026 upto 11.00 am as per tendering procedure. Tenders will be opened on Dt.11/09/2026 upto 16.00 pm or any other day with prior intimation. If there are any changes in tender, terms and conditions, TMC will have rights to issue corrigendum. It will be the responsibility of the bidder to submit the tender according to the corrigendum. Thane Municipal Corporation reserve the right to accept or reject any or all tenders without giving reasons thereof.

TMC/PRO/Health/401/2026-27 SD/-
Dated.19/08/2026 Medical Officer of Health
Pls visit our official web-site Thane Municipal Corporation www.thanecity.gov.in

**Government of India, Ministry of Home Affairs**
कार्यालय भारत के शत्रु सम्पत्ति अभिरक्षक
Office of the Custodian of Enemy Property for India
प्रथम तल, पूर्वाखण्ड (शिवाजी स्टेडियम एनक्ली) कन्ट प्लेस, नई दिल्ली-110001
First Floor, East Wing, Shivaji Stadium, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001

NOTICE OF VACANCY CIRCULAR FOR FILLING UP THE VARIOUS CONTRACTUAL POSTS
The office of the Custodian of Enemy Property for India (CEPI) is a Statutory Authority under the provisions of the Enemy Property Act, 1968. The Head Office is at Delhi with Branch Offices at Mumbai, Kolkata and Lucknow.
The CEPI is undertaking a drive for filling up various contractual posts in its Head Office in Delhi and Branch Offices at Mumbai, Kolkata and Lucknow.
The details of vacancy circular are as given below and are also available on <https://enemyproperty.mha.gov.in/epweb/vacancycircular>

S. No.	Name of Post	No. of Vacancies	Place of posting
1.	Senior Consultant	5	Delhi, Lucknow, Mumbai, Kolkata
2.	Chief Supervisor	2	Delhi, Mumbai
3.	Supervisor	2	Delhi, Lucknow
4.	Surveyor	23	Delhi, Mumbai, Lucknow, Kolkata
5.	Senior Legal Consultant	3	Delhi, Lucknow, Kolkata
6.	Project Manager (IT)	1	Delhi
7.	Data Analyst	2	Delhi

The details can also be downloaded/viewed from above website/by scanning by QR Code. The last date for submission of the application is **28.08.2026**



CBC 19148/11/0006/2627

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE No.: NIT/11/26/24, Dated:- 05.08.2026.
On behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Materials Manager, South East Central Railway, Bilaspur Division Invites e-tender for the following items:

Sr. Tender No.	Due Date	Due Time	Tender Cost ₹	EMD ₹	
1.	11256663	07.09.2026	10.30	00	2,56,77,00.00

Description:- Manufacturing & supply of Combination High Viscous Nylon (HVN) 86 Insulating Liners for use with ERC MK-II flat tile on concrete sleeper for 52Kg Rails confirming to Drg. No. RDSO/T-3707 (Gauge side liner) & T-3708 (Non Gauge side liner) (or latest Alt. if any), as per confirming to IRS Specification S. No. T-44-2023 (Second Revision) or latest. (One Set of Liner Consists of one number HVN Liner to RDSO Drg. No. T-3707 and one number HVN Liner to RDSO Drg. No. T-3708) (The alteration in drawings and specifications issued by RDSO up to Seven days before the tender closing date shall be applicable to this tender.) [Warranty Period: 36 Months after the date of delivery] Tender, please visit IREPS Website at <http://www.irops.gov.in> **Note:-** In controversial condition regarding description, English text version will be considered certified

Sr. Divl. Materials Manager/Bilaspur.
CPRI/10/PH/337 @secrail

WESTERN RAILWAY
Material Management Department
VARIOUS MATERIALS SUPPLY
E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE No. S/47/2026 Dated 17.08.2026

S.N.	Tender No	Short Description of Items	Quantity	T.O.D.
381	29262081	Drug eluting coronary stent system- Cobalt	225 Nos	21-Sep-26
382	29265004B	Spine endoscopy system for neurosurgery	2 Nos	18-Sep-26
383	22262003	Set of Axle Box Assembly Complete	17 Set	14-Sep-26
384	07265474A	SMPS Based Integrated Power Supply	51 Set	14-Sep-26
385	07265492	SMPS Based Integrated Power Supply	10 Set	12-Sep-26
386	23263929	L-type composition brake block	35630 Nos	10-Sep-26
387	27265008	Various Item of Tungsten Carbide Tamping Tools (TCTT)	92 Set	8-Sep-26

CORRIGENDUM
Please read the due date as "07.09.2026" for the Tender Notice No. S-37-2026 Dated: 10.07.2026 at Sr. No. 313.
Please read the due date as "27.08.2026" and quantity as "542.05 KM" for the Tender Notice No. S-38-2026 Dated: 14.07.2026 at Sr. No. 318.
Regarding detailed notice EMD, Purchase restrictions and detailed tender conditions, please visit website www.irops.gov.in and www.indianrailways.gov.in. 0494
Like us on: [facebook.com/WesternRly](https://www.facebook.com/WesternRly) | Follow us on: [X.com/WesternRly](https://www.x.com/WesternRly)

**जयपुर जिला कुष्ठ उत्पादक सहकारी संघ लि.**
श्री श्री गुरुदेव रविवर के पास, जयपुर-302015, फोन: 0141-2713666-69
फैसल (एड) jaipurjila@jaipurjila.com Email Id: jaipurjila@jaipurjila.com
क्रमांक (एड) जयपुरजिला.य.अ.सं., कावराता 2026/450-48 दिनांक: 18.08.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना

एचू आहार संयंत्र, कावराता पर Total Mixed Ration (TMR) Plant 5 TPH क्षमता के डिजाईन, निर्माण, स्थापना, इंस्टॉल



OPINION

The
Hindu Times
ESTABLISHED IN 1924

{ OUR TAKE }

Broken trust in temple fraud

Systemic lapses flagged by the SIT probing the siphoning of Ram Temple donations cast a shadow on the competence of temple trustees

A report from the special investigation team (SIT) exonerating two prominent former functionaries of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust might bring relief to the individuals but the systemic lapses flagged by the probe are a matter of grave concern and raise questions about the competence of the people managing one of India's most important shrines.

The report by the SIT — one of two looking into allegations of irregularities in the Ram Temple donation collections — found gross lapses in the trust's functioning, an absence of adequate checks or professional financial management and inadequate supervision at multiple levels. Damningly, the SIT found there was no dedicated finance and audit cell, no standard operating procedure for collection agents and inadequate reconciliation between donation receipts issued and money deposited. Clearly, even the basics of fiduciary responsibility were thrown to the wind, creating an opaque system where ad-hoc decisions and personal favours masqueraded as systems and processes, making the whole operation vulnerable to dubious actors.

The SIT named Ram Shankar Yadav, an aide to former trust general secretary Champat Rai, as the mastermind and blamed the eight men who have already been arrested. The report detailed specific bank accounts and shell entities allegedly used to layer the transactions and noted that some of the money was used to buy agricultural land and commercial plots. But most of these men were small-time players whose hires were overseen by trust members — some of them were even related to former trust members. How could they erect such a sophisticated operation without anyone noticing? Were the trust elders asleep at the wheel? Why didn't they declare any conflict-of-interest while hiring people they knew? Why wasn't professional management brought in at the beginning? It is not enough to just admit that mistakes were made, accountability must be fixed.

This newspaper has noted before that any scandal connected to the Ram Temple insults millions of people whose faith is tied to the shrine. It is good if no trust member was personally involved in the misappropriation but they cannot evade culpability for systemic lapses. The SIT report should pave the way for deeper investigation and introspection, not be used as a fig leaf to elide responsibility. The reforms currently underway in the trust should be sped up. And the second SIT set up by the Supreme Court should strive to fix accountability and ensure such sordid saga is never repeated.

Death penalty by any method is still death

A grave looking man — always a man — in judicial robes, with or without the peruke, pronounces “to be hanged till death” and breaks the nib of his pen after signing the relevant papers awarding capital punishment to the defendant. In Hindi cinema of a certain vintage, this was an oft repeated scene, establishing either the injustice meted out to the protagonist or fate catching up with his nemesis at last. Scriptwriters, understandably, leaned heavily on the emotion capital punishment evokes in the masses. Whether cinematic tropes were mirroring jurisprudence, or vice-versa, is actually irrelevant. What matters is that discussions on the legitimacy of capital punishment in India are as old as the Constitution. The latest debate, oddly, is only on the method of execution.

Per Section 393(5) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), executions are carried out by hanging despite the Law Commission's recommendation in 2015 that more advanced methods should be adopted. The Supreme Court (SC) has now rejected a petition challenging the constitutional validity of hanging on the grounds that it violates the right to a dignified death protected under Article 21. The SC maintained that the process causes no greater pain than any other known method and avoids “barbarity, torture and degradation”. Interestingly, the SC keeps the issue open, not precluding further government deliberation and the evolution of constitutionality. This is exactly where the punishment must take precedence over the method. By retaining the capital punishment even in the decolonised doctrine of dispensing justice, India has stuck to a relic that even the UK shed in 1965. Since India has notably progressive laws, the death penalty sticks out as a badly produced masala film from the 1980s screening at an arthouse cinema retrospective.

Sanction-proofing India's interests and autonomy

India needs a permanent Economic Security and Sanctions Office rather than a committee that meets intermittently

Recently, by 86 votes to 11, the US Senate passed a bill that could turn a barrel of crude oil bought from Russia into tariffs on Indian exports wholly unrelated to oil. The bill, however, preserved waivers for limited imports of Russian enriched uranium. Revenue from Russian energy exports helps Moscow sustain the war in Ukraine. That is a serious case for action. The harder question is who is punished, who gets waivers, and, most importantly, who decides.

The bill passed by the Senate is not yet law. If enacted, it would allow additional tariffs of up to 100% on goods exported to the US by countries that continue buying Russian oil or gas and rank among the five largest buyers, or among the five leading facilitators of Russian oil sanctions evasion. India is not named, but the scale of its Russian crude purchases places it within the formula. The trigger is oil. The leverage is Indian exports to America, from machinery and electronics to gems, jewellery and textiles. The bill also lets the President waive any duty in the US national interest.

India now has to reckon with powers that can turn economic dependence into political leverage. Washing-

ton reaches trade transactions through the dollar payment system and the American market. Brussels can restrict market access and maritime services. Beijing controls some critical industrial inputs. Each can use what others depend on to demand compliance and then decide who gets a waiver. India needs an institutional answer to that power, beyond diplomatic objections.

The US still imports 20-25% of its enriched uranium from Russia. A 2024 American law bans imports of Russian low enriched uranium but permits limited imports under individual waivers through 2027 if no viable alternative exists or the US national interest requires it. The energy department has granted Centrus, an American nuclear fuel supplier, a waiver covering deliveries already agreed to with US customers. This is Washington admitting that reactors, contracts, and fuel cycles do not rearrange themselves because the US Congress wants to uphold a principle. India can change crude suppliers more readily, though not painlessly and not overnight. The waiver thus concedes what sanctions rhetoric leaves out: Energy systems cannot be reordered on command.

In July 2025, the EU placed Nayara on its assets-freeze list. The Indian refinery is 49% owned by Rosneft, Russia's State-controlled oil company. Inclusion in the list barred people and companies subject to EU law from providing Nayara with funds or

other economic resources. The EU's sanctions on Nayara were effected through contracts as service providers and shipowners pulled back.

Measures targeting Russian petroleum work differently. Under the same package of measures that included sanctions on Nayara, the EU barred, from January 2026, imports of specified petroleum products refined from Russian crude in third countries. In March 2026, the US issued a temporary waiver (through General License 133) for the delivery



Syed Akbaruddin

and unloading in India of Russian oil already at sea. This license included necessary insurance and maritime services. A company listed for business restrictions, an import ban, and a temporary licence do not have the same legal effect. Treating all three as sanctions on India leads to the wrong response. It blurs who is acting, what rule they are relying on, and where India has room to push back.

China shows how the control of an indispensable input can become leverage. In two rounds earlier this year, it barred exports of goods with both civilian and military uses to 40 Japanese entities that Beijing linked to military activity and placed 40 more under tighter licensing. It imposed similar restrictions on 10 American companies. India depends on China for most of its imported permanent magnets. For Indian manufacturers, a licence issued or withheld in Beijing can determine whether a production line in Chennai is able to run



Sanctions can serve legitimate security purposes. But India should challenge coercion that travels far beyond the country imposing it. REUTERS

the next month or not.

India's longstanding position is that it implements UN sanctions but does not subscribe to unilateral measures imposed by individual States. This protects a vital legal principle, but it is no longer enough.

Sanctions can serve legitimate security purposes. India should instead challenge coercion that travels far beyond the country imposing it — often with inadequate notice, opaque evidence and weak review — especially when that country protects its own necessities through exemptions. If energy dependence is a reason for waivers in one country, it cannot automatically become evidence of bad faith in another.

India needs a permanent Economic Security and Sanctions Office. It must be a standing unit linking foreign policy, finance, trade, law, the RBI, petroleum, atomic energy, defence and technology rather than a committee that meets intermittently. Firms need to know what Indian law requires, which foreign rules reach their transactions, and when cau-

tious banks or suppliers are imposing restrictions required by neither Indian nor foreign law. The office should identify where alternative suppliers or lawful payment routes are needed, explain exemptions and coordinate challenges before a payment fails, a cargo is stranded or a customer walks away.

India cannot stop powerful States from using the chokepoints they control. It can contest the terms on which that power is used and insist that its own needs are accounted for. That contest over strategic autonomy will be fought in waiver clauses, licence schedules and bank compliance rooms, not only in speeches about sovereignty. If India's necessities never qualify as necessities, strategic autonomy will shrink from a doctrine into an application for somebody else's permission.

Syed Akbaruddin served as India's permanent representative to the United Nations in New York and is currently dean, Kautilya School of Public Policy. The views expressed are personal

Need to root public health education in Indian realities

The student protests focused the nation on medical education. But its poorer cousins — dental, nursing, or public health education — don't seem to be registering on the policy radar. Their problems go beyond the traditional challenges that the education sector suffers from — poor quality, lack of teachers and infrastructure. Public health education principally entails the MPH (Master of Public Health) programme with some institutions also offering undergraduate and doctoral programmes.

While clinical medicine is about diagnosing and treating individual patients, public health addresses populations or community health problems. Public health functions broadly include health surveillance, protection, promotion, planning, regulation, services organisation, delivery, and evaluation. Public health also requires a wide gamut of workforce trained in public health nutrition, occupational and environmental health, epidemiology and biostatistics, health administration and management, informatics, social sciences, economics, and policy analysis. Clinical services and public health services are complementary and together improve a nation's health.

Given the wide range of competencies required to deliver comprehensive public health, a diversity in disciplinary backgrounds of students joining the profession is necessary: medicine, allied health sciences, social sciences and law to name a few. The MPH programmes are offered by a wide variety of institutions, from medical colleges to social sciences as well as agriculture universities with each having their own eligibility criteria. At the same time, the expectation is to produce postgraduates with similar exit-level competencies. There is hardly any other professional course that has this wide diversity at the entry level and the challenge to produce a relatively homogenous end-product.

States that have a public health cadre — Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra and Odisha — currently have about one public health specialist per 100,000 population or less. Efforts are on to create a public health management cadre to meet the norm of three per 100,000 population. Even this target pales in front of the current realities in countries such as the US which has about 55 public health professionals per 100,000 population. In India, currently 125 MPH programmes produce about 5,000 postgraduates a year in contrast to the US producing about 17,000.

The basic clinical skills of recording medical history, measuring pulse, auscultation of breaths and heart sounds are universal; what differs across countries is their interpretation. High fever in a patient can mean malaria in a specific season or typhoid or dengue in other places or seasons.

Similarly, basic public health competencies and principles of epidemiology, biostatistics, management, social sciences or communication are universal but contexts and local particularities have a bearing on community behaviours, health systems, programmes or policies. MPH programmes in India are rooted in Western models which may train candidates in the same competencies but miss out real-world Indian contexts. MPH programmes are run as classroom courses that are highly sanitised, an antithesis of both a public health

course and discourse.

The lack of a centralised regulatory body is taking a toll on quality of these courses. Regulation of MPH programmes has fallen between two stools — National Medical Commission (NMC) and University Grants Commission (UGC). Since medical, dental, and AYUSH graduates account for the bulk of MPH candidates, should it be regulated by these councils? At the same time, MPH is not inherently a medical, dental or AYUSH degree. Many non-medical universities regulated by the UGC offer this degree too. Aligning MPH programmes with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and the UGC framework which advocates academic flexibility, credit transfer, and multiple entry-exit options is a challenge given that this is a professional course.

Do we have a credible road map for reform? A group of concerned academics (both of us are part of it) have initiated efforts to advocate for corrective measures. The group recently released its report and we summarise its key findings and recommendations here.

First, India needs to expand to a broad-based public health service, beyond mere clinical provision. There is a need to advocate for a specialised public health cadre in all the states and open up career opportunities for trained MPH professionals. In the event of India failing to expand to a diverse set of functions and activities, MPH graduates may face the same challenges that dental and engineering graduates faced earlier — closure of these colleges and an uncertain future. There is a need for better

management of the demand and supply of public health workforce to address the present deficiency, but also to not end up with over-production of the professionals.

Uniform and inclusive eligibility criteria nationwide need to be established to ensure consistency, transparency, and inclusiveness. The entry criteria for MPH programmes must reflect the field's interdisciplinary nature and include those with health, science, and social science disciplinary backgrounds. Introduction of key foundational courses is critical to ensure that everyone is at the same stage at the start of the course.

India-specific MPH programmes need to be designed while adopting best global practices to address India's disease burden with a focus on primary health care. Public health schools must impart a basic and uniform set of skills and competencies and ensure sufficient time is allocated to acquire these. Adequate exposure to health system and primary health care should be ensured.

Like any professional course, MPH degree needs accreditation systems and councils. A separate Public Health Education Council of India should be set up, which should be an apical, multidisciplinary body that sets standards, accredits programmes, fosters interdisciplinary collaboration, and promotes workforce development.

Public health education in India needs to be anchored in the country's realities to deliver the maximum efficacy.

Anand Krishnan is a professor at the All-India Institute Medical Sciences, New Delhi, and Rajib Dasgupta is a professor at the Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi. The views expressed are personal

{ ABDULLAH ABU SHAWESH } PALESTINE AMBASSADOR TO INDIA



It came in a very critical time... when the health sector in Palestine is in the brink of collapse... and India is one of the country that we reach out to help us

On the upcoming hospital being built by India in the West Bank



India's photographic identity: Who gets to tell this tale?

We have arrived at the 80th Independence Day, and World Photography Day, first proposed by OP Sharma, a Delhi-based photography teacher, is observed in the same month. Independence was also a claim to authorship, a newly independent country deciding it would no longer be described by somebody else's visual storytelling.

Photography arrived in India in 1840, and for decades after, its record was largely made by people who did not live inside the country, and what got published was rarely made by an Indian photographer. It is worth asking whether the work of reclaiming authorship is finished, or whether it has changed shape into something harder to see.

On the surface, the answer seems to be yes, since a billion phones here now produce a huge share of the world's daily picture-making. But volume is never the same thing as authorship. This isn't about copyright, nobody's ownership of the image itself is in question. A country can photograph its own people more than at any point in its history and still not own the image of itself that actually circulates in the world's mind. What's actually at stake is whose picture of India gets noticed, whose name travels with it, and whose gets left out. Deciding which picture of India becomes the picture of India no longer sits with an editor in Delhi or London. It sits with an algorithm nobody elected, and with the aggregator accounts that have learned to feed it, repackaging images as evidence of a country rather than one person's way of seeing it.

For decades that gaze arrived with a foreign photographer's passport, and Indian photography spent that period contesting it. Raghubir Singh stood as its antithesis, rejecting the inherited monochrome altogether and building a colour vocabulary out of Indian miniature painting instead. He argued that black carried the guilt of the West, tied to death in a way colour never was in India.

Unfortunately, what remains is still the same thing, the Holi celebration, a camel fair in Nagaur, the temple in Puri, or a widow in Vrindavan, and none of it needs a foreign passport now.

Photographer Soham Gupta lived this from the inside. His early work on Calcutta's destitute was criticised as a continuing colonial gaze, made by an Indian in his own city. A culture this saturated, this willing to be

photographed, makes it easy for any algorithm to reward the same spectacle an outsider once had to travel here to find, only this time nobody needs a fixer or a visa to get it.

It's also worth remembering there are photographers resisting the pull of all this. Among them, Gauri Gill, Sohrab Hura, Poulomi Basu, each building something different.

None of this argues for the old gatekeepers coming back, since money, training and access kept most of the country out for decades. Responsibility has simply moved to whoever holds the phone.

The test is not whether a picture is well composed. It is whether you are actually interested in telling something through it, or only about making your presence felt. A ladder left lying flat against a soot-blackened wall, something small and dried caught between its rungs, is not the kind of photograph anyone posts under a festival's name. It asks nothing of the viewer except to notice it was there. Nothing decorative does that.

Most of us are too shy to walk up to a stranger with a camera, but a great many of us sit next to one every week without noticing, an Uber driver, the drive and conversation grant access a stranger on the street never would, and there is your portrait, ready-made. Ask permission once, keep it simple, and repeat it ride after ride until it becomes a whole body of work. An algorithm trained to reward a single striking frame has no real appetite for that.

The real reward for a photographer is making a story, not feeding a formula that has run for over a century now. And most of the time, that's exactly what we end up doing, without even noticing.

Independent India started finding its own photography identity, but that search isn't finished. The question still remains whether current image-making amounts to real ownership or only to volume. No algorithm, no platform is going to decide that for us. It gets decided the ordinary way, one story at a time, by whoever bothers to actually look before hitting that shutter, and by how many times they are willing to go back to it.

Samar Jodha is a transdisciplinary artist, photographer and TED speaker, and an advisor to Museo Camera, the photography museum and archive in Gurugram. The views expressed are personal

Gulf nations warned against helping US

Agence France-Presse

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TEHRAN: Iran's armed forces warned Gulf countries against assisting the US military on Wednesday, hours after the United Arab Emirates announced it was severing economic ties with Tehran following new attacks on shipping.

The Gulf is dotted with US military installations, including in the UAE, which said on Tuesday that Iran had fired two ballistic missiles at vessels off its coast.

Despite a recent lull in hostilities between the United States and Iran, the Strait of Hormuz — which Tehran has blockaded — remains a flashpoint, and attacks on commercial ships have continued. A framework US-Iran deal aimed at reopening the vital trade corridor collapsed, and although both sides recently said messages were being exchanged, US President Donald Trump on Tuesday insisted talks were off, taunting Iran with a social media post depicting the strait as a "NEW U.S. Territory".

Iranian armed forces chief of staff Ali Abdollahi, according to the Mehr news agency, warned



Aircraft carrier USS Abraham Lincoln which is supporting US military operations in West Asia, conducts a replenishment-at-sea with fleet replenishment oiler USNS Henry J. Kaiser. REUTERS

"any assistance or facilitation provided to the aggressor US military amounts to participation in the US military operation".

The conflict broke out on February 28 with US-Israeli attacks on the Islamic republic, which retaliated with missile and drone strikes across the region.

Since the start of the war, many Middle Eastern countries have said they would not allow the United States to use their territory as a launchpad for attacks, though Abdollahi cast doubt on those promises. "It seems unlikely

that such a large number of military aircraft, particularly refuelling aircraft, could be present at regional bases without knowledge of host countries," said Abdollahi, adding Gulf countries "should know that we are fully aware of the situation".

Media outlets have reported that Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, Kuwait and Bahrain have all hit targets in Iran in retaliation for Tehran's attacks on the Gulf, though the countries have mostly denied the reports.



Hind Rajab

ISRAELI ARMY ADMITS FIRING THAT KILLED HIND RAJAB

Agence France-Presse

letters@hindustantimes.com

JERUSALEM: The Israeli military on Wednesday admitted its troops fired on a car carrying five-year-old Hind Rajab in Gaza in 2024, saying it had ordered a criminal investigation into the killing which drew international outrage.

Hind Rajab's body was recovered from a car riddled with bullets in Gaza City days after she was last heard from in a desperate, hours-long phone call to the Palestinian Red Crescent on January 29, 2024.

The Israeli military had previously denied its troops were present in the area near the incident.

"Following review of the findings and due to alleged failures in the coordination of the movement of the Palestine Red Crescent ambulance, it has been decided to initiate a criminal investigation of the incident by Military Police Criminal Investigation Division," the military said on Wednesday.

Alongside the Hind Rajab case, the military published reviews into four other high-profile incidents in Gaza, saying it was also launching a criminal probe into the 2025 killings of 15 Palestinians including medics and humanitarian personnel.

Hind Rajab had made the emergency call after her family's car came under fire during an attempt to flee Gaza City amid an Israeli advance in the Palestinian territory's north. Her body was eventually recovered along with those of six relatives and two Red Crescent rescue workers sent to find her.

Dozen protesting Indian students now potentially can't enter Canada

Anirudh Bhattacharyya

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TORONTO: Canadian border agents deemed a dozen Indian students potentially inadmissible to Canada under the country's immigration and refugee protection law after checking the status of 20 of them at a protest in Calgary in the western province of Alberta, a Canada Border Services Agency (CBSA) spokesperson said on Tuesday.

About 1,500 students at Calgary's Portage College began a demonstration and hunger strike on July 24 against the retroactive rejection and cancellation of their post-graduation work permits. Hundreds of students from India have been refused these permits because they enrolled in non-credit courses that did not provide a certificate, diploma, or a degree. The permit denial put their immigration status in limbo. The denial followed an



Students protesting in Calgary, Canada in late July. RED FM CALGARY

updated policy by Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC) that retroactively disqualified graduates of "non-credit" college programmes. IRCC is the department in charge of immigration, refugees, and citizenship.

The CBSA spokesperson told The Globe and Mail newspaper that foreign nationals admitted to Canada are unable to work or

study unless authorised and are expected to depart Canada at the end of their authorised period of stay. "When the CBSA becomes aware of foreign nationals who may be inadmissible to Canada, CBSA officers will investigate and take appropriate action."

The Globe and Mail reported that Calgary Police asked CBSA to conduct a "status check" on four people at the protest and subsequently found that two of them were not in compliance with their immigration status.

Immigration lawyer Sumit Sen said such international students face the prospect of returning home after a shattered dream. He added that the question remains whether IRCC has the power to implement a rule that applies retroactively. The presence of border agents at the protest venue was unprecedented in recent Canadian history. Videos of the CBSA agents at the site were posted on social media.

U.S., CANADA SAY THEY ARE CLOSE TO FINAL TRADE DEAL

Agence France-Presse

letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: The US and Canada signalled on Wednesday that they were close to finalising a comprehensive trade deal, after President Donald Trump paused implementing a new round of crippling tariffs. "We've come to a deal with Canada," Trump said on Wednesday, adding that it's "subject to finalisation of documents".

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney remained more cautious, saying on social media that Ottawa and Washington "are now moving towards an agreement".

The planned US tariffs, set at 50% percent, were originally due to take effect Wednesday on select Canadian goods.

But Trump announced late Tuesday that he would delay their rollout by three days as both sides worked to finalise a deal.

HARVARD TO PAY \$53 MILLION AFTER MORGUE MANAGER SOLD BODY PARTS

WASHINGTON: Harvard University has agreed to pay a \$53 million settlement to resolve lawsuits by families after its former morgue manager stole and sold body parts donated for scientific research, with a Boston court reportedly approving the plan on Tuesday.

Cedric Lodge, who managed the morgue at the Harvard Medical School before being fired in 2023, was sentenced to eight years in prison in December. Investigators said Lodge and his wife took body parts from the school "without the knowledge or permission of his employer; the donor, or the donor's family" and shipped them to buyers in other states since 2018.

The Harvard Medical School will set up an annual scholarship starting in the 2027-28 academic year "in appreciation and in honour of all of our anatomical donors."

US Green Card seekers to face broader scrutiny from Sept 18

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: Immigrants seeking Green Cards or permanent residency in the US will face fresh hurdles as the Trump administration has expanded the definition of "public charge" to deny applications to those availing benefits such as Medicaid, food stamps or any subsistence aid from the government.

The new rule finalised by the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) comes into effect from September 18 and will also hit Indians seeking Green Cards.

An earlier rule only considered two types of public benefits as grounds for denying a Green Card application: cash assistance for income maintenance and long-term institutionalisation at the government's expense.

"To make public charge inad-

missibility determinations, USCIS officers will consider the five statutory factors and any other factor relevant to assessing the alien's likelihood at any time of becoming a public charge, including the alien's receipt of means-tested public benefits, such as cash assistance for income maintenance, housing assistance, food stamps, financial aid for college, or any other similar benefit," an official statement said.

The guidance follows the Department of Homeland Security's decision to rescind the 2022 Biden-era public charge regulations. The final rule was announced on July 16 and published in the Federal Register on July 20.

It will apply to Forms I-485 seeking permanent residence or adjustment of status that are postmarked or electronically submitted on or after September

18. The new rule allows USCIS officers to count age, health, family status, finances, educational background, and even the use of public benefits by an applicant's dependants, regardless of that dependant's status, against that applicant's chances for approval.

If a USCIS officer finds that an alien applying for adjustment of status to that of a lawful permanent resident in the United States is inadmissible only because they are likely at any time to become a public charge, the USCIS officer may invite the alien to post a public charge bond.

Of the nearly 1.2 million people who received a Green Card in 2023, about 78,100 (6.5%) were from India.

That year, 60% of Indians who received a Green Card did so either as an immediate relative of a US citizen or Green Card holder or as another family member of a citizen.

Trump says will meet North Korean leader

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump said on Wednesday he would meet North Korean leader Kim Jong-un later this year, in what would be their first encounter of Trump's second term. "Yeah, I will be," Trump when asked if he planned to meet Kim.

Pak govt seeks review of Imran Khan order

ISLAMABAD: The Pakistan government on Wednesday petitioned the Supreme

Court, seeking a review and recall of its order to shift jailed former prime minister Imran Khan to a private hospital.

Indian student injured in drone attack in Russia

MOSCOW: An Indian student in Russia sustained minor injuries in a Ukrainian drone attack on Wednesday and is undergoing treatment at a hospital, the Indian Embassy in Moscow said.

The Indian national was identified as a student at the Bashkir State Medical University in Ufa.

Thousands of Indian students go to Russia for higher education every year - most of them to pursue medical courses.

Gold mine collapse kills 100 people in CAR

BOUAR: A landslide at an illegal gold mine has killed at least 100 people in the Central African Republic (CAR) on the border with Cameroon on Tuesday.

The incident occurred at the Zamboye mining site, about 50km from the Central African town of Baboua, on Tuesday. n its path.



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER
RURAL WORKS CIRCLE, RAYAGADA
Email ID-cerwcrayagada@gmail.com
Letter No. 2671 Date: 18.08.2026

25001/968/2627

1st Corrigendum

In Continuation to this office bid identification No. NCB-13/RWCRGDA/2026-2027 invited vide this office letter No-2558 dated.01.08.2026 partial modification of TCN has been made as follows

Sl.No.	Item	Time schedule as per Original TCN	Time schedule as per Corrigendum Notice
1	Availability of tender online for bidding	DI. 05.08.2026 at 11.00 A.M. to DI. 20.08.2026 Up to 5.00 P.M.	Extended from DI.20.08.2026 at 5.00 P.M. up to 5.00 P.M. of DI.03.09.2026
2	Date & time of seeking tender clarification if any	19.08.2026 Up to 5.00 P.M.	DI.02.09.2026 Up to 5.00 P.M.
3	Date & time of opening of tender (Technical Bid)	DI. 21.08.2026 At 11.00 A.M.	DI.05.09.2026 At 11.00 A.M.
4	Date & time of opening of tender (Price Bid)	Will intimated be intimated later on to the successful bidders	Will be intimated later on to the successful bidders

All other terms & conditions will remain unchanged

Chief Construction Engineer,
RW Circle, Rayagada
OIPR - 25001/25196/126-27/0030



WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY
MATERIAL MANAGEMENT DEPARTMENT
(e-TENDER NOTICE FOR THE SUPPLY OF STORES, NO. EPS/26/2026)
PCMM/WCR on behalf of the President of India invites the following advertised tenders through E-procurement System. Manual/postal offers shall not be entertained. Tenders can be accessed under the link <https://ireps.gov.in> for details and for submission of Tender.

Sr.No.	Tender No.	Short Description	Tendered Qty
1	50265020	PVC Insulated armoured, unscreened, Underground Railway signalling cable of size 12C x 1.5 Sq.mm	125.91 Kilometre
2	38264156	ATL TORSION SPRING (STEEL) FOR TWIST LOCK	3764 Nos.
3	20264115	CYLINDRICAL ROLLER AXLE BOX BEARING	253 Nos.
4	50265027	25 Watt VHF Set- Supply of Trans receiver VHF digital radio	195 Nos.
5	61262421	Vinyl Coated Upholstery Fabric for AC coaches	19291 Metre.
6	80261064	Engine oil SAE 15W 40 CI-4 Plus grade lubricant oil	45340 Litre.
7	38262403A	Booster Suspension spring Snubber for 22 HS bogies	15560 Nos.
8	80261139A	DISSOLVED ACETYLENE GAS TO IS: 308/1988	109600 Cum.

Due Date for Sr.no.1: 24.08.2026, Sr.no.2: 09.09.2026, Sr.no.3: 11.09.2026, Sr.no.4,5: 15.09.2026, Sr.no.6: 16.09.2026, Sr.no.7: 21.09.2026, Sr.no.8: 23.10.2026. For tenders with estimated value below ₹ 50 Lakh, interested firms are advised to visit www.ireps.gov.in (SD.)

For Principal Chief Material Manager, WCR, Jabalpur



WESTERN RAILWAY
AHMEDABAD DIVISION

OUTSOURCING OF AC COACH ELECTRICAL ATTENDANT FOR VARIOUS COACHES

E-Tender Notice No. Sr. DEE/ADI/29 (26-27) dt. 18.08.2026

Tender No. EL-ADI-G-T-20-2026-27

Name of Work: Ahmedabad Division - Outsourcing of AC coach Electrical Attendant for Escorting, Operation & Troubleshooting of LHB AC, SG AC & Vande Bharat coaches of primary maintenance trains of Ahmedabad Area (ICD SBI, RAJ & KKF) for two years. Estimated Cost: ₹ 9.91,28,109.19/- Earnest Money: ₹ 19,82,600/- Date & Time of submission and opening: Not later than 15:00 Hrs. of 15-09-2026 and 15-09-2026 at 15:30 Hrs. Address of the office: Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer, D.R.M. Office (W.R.), Near Chamunda Bridge, Opp. G.C.S. Hospital, Naroda Road, Amdapura, Ahmedabad - 382345. Website details: www.ireps.gov.in ADI-140

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WESTERN RAILWAY - AHMEDABAD DIVISION

VARIOUS ENGINEERING WORKS

e-Tender Notice No. 17 of 2026-27 dated : 19.08.2026

Sr. No.	e-Tender No.	Name of work	Approximate NIT Cost (₹)	EMD Cost (₹)
01	DRM-ADI-126-2026-27	Cleaning of Over Head tanks and Underground sumps under jurisdiction of Senior Divisional Engineer (West) Ahmedabad.	39,90,028.50	79,800.00

(For 02 Years)

02	DRM-ADI-127-2026-27	Construction of new Track Machine Sidings, Through Fitting Renewal (TFR), Casual Renovation of Rails and ancillary works of track under the jurisdiction of Sr.DEN (North)-Ahmedabad.	2,01,23,932.26	4,02,500.00
03	DRM-ADI-128-2026-27	Construction of 3-Meter wide Foot Over Bridge at Dhinaj Station and other ancillary works under the jurisdiction of Sr. Divisional Engineer (North)-Ahmedabad.	3,49,82,341.60	6,99,700.00
04	DRM-ADI-129-2026-27	Samakhiali-Gandhidham-New Bhuj-Naliya section-Pre & post tamping track measurement survey using Tumble Gedd Vorsys trolley system in the jurisdiction of ADEN-Gandhidham.	1,32,10,441.82	2,64,200.00
05	DRM-ADI-130-2026-27	Gandhidham-New Bhuj Section: Rebuilding of minor bridges (20 Nos.) Br. No. 9 at Km 10/600, 11 at Km 11/414.	43,68,17,616.44	87,36,400.00

17A at km 19/370, 17B at km 19/579, 19 at km 23/102, 20 at km 23/347, 22 at km 24/081, 26 at Km 29/266, 31 at km 41/065, 37 at km 44/507, 39 at 45/126, 41 at km 46/206, 42 at km 47/144, 43 at km 47/466, 44 at km 47/627, 45 at km 47/736, 46 at km 48/474, 49 at km 52/502, 64 at Km 57/814 & 65 at km 58/436 under jurisdiction of Sr.DEN(NW)-ADI. (Re-invited)

06	DRM-ADI-131-2026-27	Supply of Potable Drinking Water by Road Tankers at New Palanpur Running Room for a Duration of One Year.	25,24,700.31	50,500.00
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Closing date and time of e-tender: Date 15-09-2026 at 15:00 Hrs. Office Address : Sr. Divisional Engineer (Co-ordination), Ahmedabad, DRM Office, Nr. Chamunda Bridge, Opp. New Swadeshi Mill, Naroda Road, Amdapura, Ahmedabad-382345. Website for participating e-tender: www.ireps.gov.in ADI-142

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Branch Office: ICICI Bank Ltd, Ground Floor, Akruti Centre, MIDC, Near Telephone Exchange, Opp Akruti Star, Andheri East, Mumbai- 400093.

PUBLIC NOTICE-TENDER CUM E-AUCTION FOR SALE OF SECURED ASSET

(See proviso to Rule 8(i))
Notice for sale of immovable asset(s)

E-Auction Sale Notice for the sale of immovable asset(s) under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

This notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/ charged to the Secured Creditor, the Constructive possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of ICICI Bank Limited will be sold on 'As is where is', 'As is what is' and 'Whatever there is' as per the brief particulars given hereunder;

Sr. No.	Name of Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrowers/ Guarantors/ Loan Account No.	Details of the Secured asset(s) with known encumbrances, if any	Amount Outstanding	Reserve Price/ Earnest Money Deposit	Date and Time of Property Inspection	Date & Time of E-Auction
(A)	(B)	(C)	(D)	(E)	(F)	(G)
1.	Mrs. Pooja Sanjay Mishra (Borrower) Mr. Sanjay Rajkumar Mishra (Co-Borrower) Loan No. LBMUM00005611926	Flat No. 202, 2nd Floor, Sale Wing Known As Supreme, Composite Building D, Project Known As "Avant Hillway", Building Known As "Avant Hillway Supreme", Off A K Vaidya Marg, Beside Swapnolok Building, CTS No. 610A/1B/2, 610A/1B, CTS No. 610 (Part), Survey No. 267 Part, Village Malad (East), Tal- Borivoli, Mumbai- 400063, Admeasuring An Area of About 625 Sq Ft's Rera Carpet Area : Area 63.89 Sq Mtr	Rs. 99,98,000/- As On August 18, 2026	Rs. 1,29,00,000/- Rs. 12,90,000/-	September 15, 2026 From 11:00 AM To 02:00 PM	September 25, 2026 From 11:00 AM Onward
2.	Mr. Pawan Chandulal Khemani (Borrower) Mr. Kamal Chandulal Khemani (Co-Borrower) Loan No. LBMUM00004873184	Flat No. 1201, 12th Floor, Tower C-Wing, Elite Bldg, Enmrad Runwal Elegante, Opp Infinity Mall, Lokhandwala Complex, Oshiwara Andheri West, Maharashtra, Mumbai- 400058, Admeasuring An Area of 1925 Sq.ft. Carpet Area Equivalent To 214.68 Sq.mtrs. Built Up Area Alongwith Two Car Parking At Podium 3 Level No. 80 & 90	Rs. 2,32,11,770/- As On August 18, 2026	Rs. 9,87,70,000/- Rs. 98,77,000/-	September 15, 2026 From 11:00 AM To 02:00 PM	September 25, 2026 From 11:00 AM Onward

The online auction will take place on the website (URL Link-<https://BidDeal.in/>) of e-auction agency ValueTrust Capital Services Private Limited. The Mortgagors/notice are given a last chance to pay the total dues with further interest till September 24, 2026 before 05:00 PM failing which, these secured assets will be sold as per schedule. The Prospective Bidder(s) must submit the Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) Demand Draft (DD) (Refer Column E) at ICICI Bank Limited, Level 3-5, 74 Techno Park, Opp SEEPZ Gate No. 02, Marol MIDC, Andheri East, Mumbai-400093 on or before September 24, 2026 before 04:00 PM and thereafter they need to submit their offer through the above mentioned website only on or before September 24, 2026 before 05:00 PM along with scan image of Bank acknowledged DD towards proof of payment of EMD. Kindly note, in case prospective bidder(s) are unable to submit their offer through the website then signed copy of tender documents may be submitted at ICICI Bank Limited, Level 3-5, 74 Techno Park, Opp SEEPZ Gate No. 02, Marol MIDC, Andheri East, Mumbai- 400093 on or before September 24, 2026 before 05:00 PM. Earnest Money Deposit DD/PO should be from a Nationalised/ Scheduled Bank in favour of "ICICI Bank Limited" payable at "Mumbai". For any further clarifications with regards to inspection, terms and conditions of the e-auction or submission of tenders, kindly contact ICICI Bank Limited on 7304915594/9004392416. The Authorised Officer reserves the right to reject any or all the bids without furnishing any further reasons. For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please visit www.icicibank.com/n4p4s Date : August 20, 2026 Place: Mumbai

Authorized Officer
ICICI Bank Limited



MAHATMA PHULE KRISHI VIDYAPEETH,
RAHURI - 413 722, DIST-AHILYANAGAR

Office of the University Engineer
Phone (02426) 243 272, 243235 (Office), 243601 (fax)
Web: www.mpkv.mah.nic.in, e-mail-uniengineermpkv@gmail.com
No. MPKV/WRK/CT/3164/2026 Dated : 19/08/2026

e- Tender Notice

The University Engineer invites online e-tenders in B-1 form from the registered Electrical contractors in appropriate class registered in state PWD/Central PWD/ Military Engineering services and Railway Department for the following works at Govt. College of Agriculture, Nandurbar.

Sr. No.	Name of work	Estimated cost (Rs.)
1	Providing Internal and External electrical installation for the Amenity building (G) Library Building (G+1), Gymnasium Hall at Govt. College of Agriculture, Nandurbar under MPKV Rahuri.	87,63,973.00

For Detail Tender Notice please see website Portal <https://mahatenders.gov.in>,
Organization- Department of Agricultural, Sd/-
Department- Mahatma Phule Krishi Vidyapeeth, Rahuri. University Engineer
Division- Mahatma Engineer MPKV, Rahuri.



Power Jobs

WANTED PRINCIPAL

A CBSE affiliated English Medium Co-Educational high school in South Gujarat, with over 2000 plus students, run by a Charitable Trust is looking for a principal with a progressive and modern outlook.

The suitable candidate should be around 40-50 years of age, having experience in a senior position, in a similar institution to manage all regular school operations and provide strong leadership, who should be well-versed with the latest teaching learning pedagogies and assessment patterns.

The post carries an attractive package of housing and negotiable salary.

Eligible candidates may apply within 10 days of publication of the advertisement.

Interested applicants may share their updated CV on squaratschoolhire@gmail.com



Stock Holding Corporation Of India Limited

Regd. Office : 301, Centre Point, Dr.Babasaheb Ambedkar Road, Parel, Mumbai-400 012
CIN : U67190MH1986GOI040506

RECRUITMENT NOTICE

StockHolding invites applications from the eligible candidates for the following positions under Fixed Term Engagement (FTE):

Sr.No.	Title of the Position	No. of Positions
1.	CISO - Location - Mumbai/ Navi Mumbai	01
2	Dy. CISO - Location - Mumbai / Navi Mumbai	01
3.	Executive- FTE	65

Locations & No. of Post

Andhra Pradesh	02	Arunachal Pradesh	01	Assam	02
Chandigarh	01	Chhattisgarh	03	Delhi	09
Gujarat	10	Jammu & Kashmir	01	Mizoram	01
Nagaland	02	Odisha	02	Puducherry	01
Punjab	06	Rajasthan	09	Tamil Nadu	08
Tripura	01	Uttarakhand	01	Uttar Pradesh	05

Online Test will be conducted for Executive (FTE) Position on 06-Sept.2026

The eligibility criteria and other details along with a link for online submission of applications are available on the Careers page of the Corporation's website i.e. <https://corporate.stockholding.com/careers/>

Application to be received only in online mode through the Career page of StockHolding.

For Executive (FTE) online application window will open after 11:00 AM on August 19, 2026 and will be available till 6.00 PM on August 30, 2026.

For CISO and Dy. CISO application window will open after 11:00 AM on August 19, 2026 and will be available till 6.00 PM on September 02, 2026.

Vice President
HWD Department, Mumbai



GOVERNMENT OF PUNJAB
DEPARTMENT OF POWER
(Energy Branch)

ADVERTISEMENT FOR THE POST OF DIRECTOR/FINANCE & COMMERCIAL IN PUNJAB STATE TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LIMITED

Applications are invited from eligible candidates for the post of Director/ Finance & Commercial in Punjab State Transmission Corporation Limited.

For details, login to www.punjab.gov.in, www.pserc.gov.in, www.pstcl.in and www.pstcl.org Last date of receipt of applications is 17.09.2026 till 5.00 PM.

RO No. 1078/12/2026/27/14407

SPORT

Suthar takes 10, India boost WTC hopes

India win in their 600th Test by 165 runs vs SL, pocket 12 points to stay in the run for the WTC final

Somshuvra Laha

somshuvra.laha@htlive.com

KOLKATA: Manav Suthar picked up 10 wickets as India defeated Sri Lanka by 165 runs at Galle on Wednesday, ensuring the visitors can look back at their 600th Test with fond memories. This was the left-arm spinner's second five-wicket haul as India secured 12 World Test Championship points to keep them firmly in the race for next year's final, while Sri Lanka were left to contemplate how quickly a promising position had become a heavy defeat.

This was India's fifth win in 10 Tests in the current WTC cycle and their first victory since they beat West Indies in Ahmedabad last year. India's PCT increased from 48.14 to 53.33 after the win. However, they remain fifth in the WTC standings, behind Australia (77.77), South Africa (75.00), New Zealand (72.22) and Bangladesh (66.67).

India have one more Test left in the Sri Lanka series before travelling to New Zealand for a two-Test series. Their WTC campaign will end with a five-Test Border-Gavaskar Trophy series against Australia at home next year.

If India manage to win all eight remaining Tests, their final points percentage could reach 74.07%, which would put them in an excellent position to make the final.

Resuming on their overnight score of 84 for four, Sri Lanka moved to 142 before losing two big wickets in the span of 26 balls. The scalp of first innings centurion Sonal Dinusha triggered an extraordinary collapse as Sri Lanka lost the remaining four wickets for just eight runs. It was the kind of culmination India were seeking after getting almost everything right on the go.

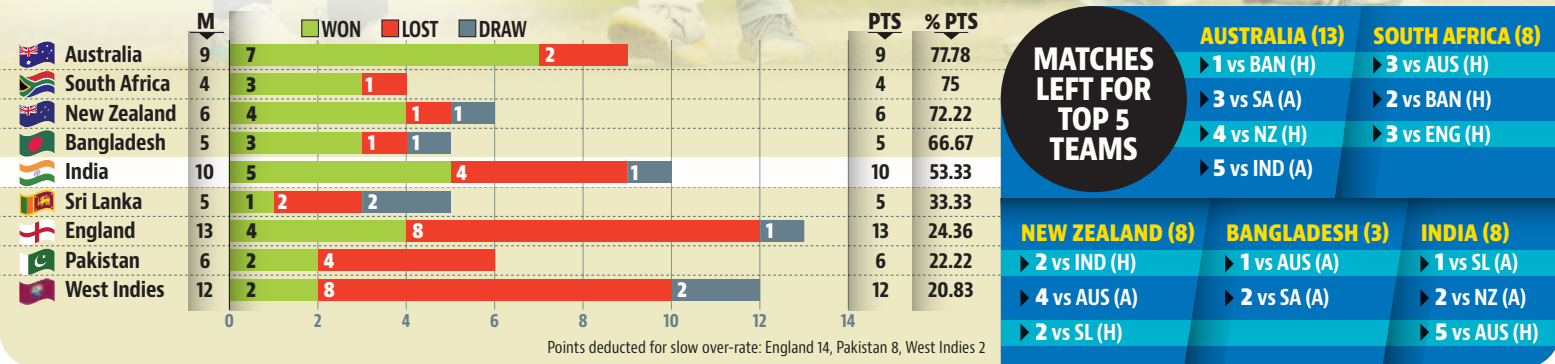
Shubman Gill won the toss and, on a slow surface that offered enough encouragement to spin without turning into a minefield, made the advantage count. Their victory was built initially by a No.3 playing only his third Test and finished by a left-arm spinner playing his second.

Devdutt Padikkal's 167 was the foundation. He battled with the authority of a player who appeared to understand exactly what the conditions demanded, resisting the temptation to manufacture scoring opportunities and instead allowing the runs to accumulate. His hundred gave



India's Manav Suthar (C) celebrates after dismissing SL's Prabath Jayasuriya on Day 5 of the first Test in Galle on Wednesday. PTI

WTC standings



SCORECARD

India 1st innings 462
Sri Lanka 1st innings 284
India 2nd innings 193
Sri Lanka 2nd innings (Overnight 84/4)
D de Silva c Suthar b Jadeja 59
S Dinusha c Jurel b Suthar 84
N Dickwella c Pant b Prasad 10
K Nuwantha b Suthar 20
P Jayasuriya b Suthar 20
L Kumara c Pant b Suthar 0
A Fernando not out 0
Extras (b 5, lb 1, nb 3) 9
Total (all out in 774 ovs) 206
FOW: 1-13, 2-14, 3-21, 4-47, 5-142, 6-156, 7-199, 8-199, 9-199
Bowling: Siraj 9-2-15-1, Suthar 23-4-55-6, Prasad 10-3-16-2, Jadeja 23-3-71-1, Kuldeep 11-0-38-0, Padikkal 1-0-5-0.

India a 178-run first-innings lead but equally crucial was the second innings 44 that provided the spinners a substantial margin for error.

Suthar exploited that beauti-

fully. The most intriguing aspect of his bowling was not simply the amount of turn he generated but his ability to vary it without making his intentions obvious. There was the classical left-arm spinner's delivery—flighted, drifting in, pitching on a teasing length and biting away. But there was also the quicker ball, pushed through at more than 90kph, which arrived before the batter expected it and often straightened. That combination proved devastating.

Sri Lanka's resistance in the final innings had, for a while, seemed to require India to work much harder than the final margin suggests. Dhananjaya de Silva and Sonal Dinusha put together a 95-run partnership from 202 balls, displaying precisely the sort of patience that can frustrate a fourth-innings attack on a pitch that seemed to flatten out. For the first hour, India had little to show for their efforts even as Mohammed Siraj

and Ravindra Jadeja toiled away. Dinusha, who had already made a hundred in the first innings, moved serenely towards another.

He reached 50 with a six off Kuldeep Yadav and appeared destined to become the first Sri Lankan batter to turn the match into a genuine final-day problem for India. Dhananjaya was equally stubborn. He had survived the previous evening after Jadeja overstepped when he had the Sri Lankan captain caught at slip.

This time, however, there was no reprieve. Jadeja broke the partnership in the 56th over, finding the top edge of an uncharacteristic sweep from Dhananjaya and then watching Suthar take the catch at short fine leg.

That was the wicket India needed, but what followed mattered more.

Prasidh Krishna removed Nirishan Dickwella, who had spent

much of his brief stay at the crease trying to manufacture momentum. The conversation between Dickwella and Yashasvi Jaiswal—fielding at close—before the dismissal had provided a lighter interlude. Jaiswal promising to take him to IPL if he attacked the bowling. Dickwella tried, Prasidh Krishna cashed in. That left Sri Lanka's tail exposed, and Suthar did not waste the opportunity.

The 75th over was the decisive burst. Dinusha, having batted for 128 balls and reached 84, finally fell to a soft dismissal, insid- edging a flighted delivery onto his pad and offering a catch at leg gully. Two balls later, Prabath Jayasuriya was bowled by a delivery that gripped and spun past his defensive stroke. Suthar was suddenly on a hat-trick.

He didn't get it, but the manner of the next wicket was revealing. Lahiru Kumara played for turn against a ball that didn't turn. It trimmed the outside edge

and disappeared into Rishabh Pant's gloves, giving Suthar his second five-for in two Tests. Two overs later, he finished the job himself.

There is a temptation to be carried away by a young spinner's numbers, particularly on a Galle surface and against a low-order exposed to pressure. Yet Suthar's performance suggested something more substantial than favourable circumstances. He showed control and variation, qualities that India will value enormously as the WTC cycle develops.

It is still a long road in their campaign for the World Test Championship final. But this was the sort of win India needed—comprehensive, built around a major first-innings contribution from a young batter, and sealed by another young bowler with a remarkably high bar. In what has been a challenging transition period, that's a laudable start for India.

Subtle variations make Suthar special: KL Rahul

Somshuvra Laha

somshuvra.laha@htlive.com

KOLKATA: In the game of a bowler posing a question to a batter who must come up with an adequate answer or perish, Manav Suthar can be quite the improviser. And even though two Tests aren't quite enough evidence, the 24-year-old's body of work already demands a nuanced analysis. Three deliveries across three sessions uphold the sentiment that maybe Suthar is for the long haul after all.

The first, to Pasindu Sooriyabandara on the fourth day, was almost a question of geometry. Suthar floated the ball on middle and leg, offered little spin and allowed the delivery to continue on its original trajectory.

Sooriyabandara played for the defensive inside edge; there was none. The ball struck him on the back leg, and after India reviewed the decision, ball-tracking confirmed three reds.

To Sonal Dinusha, who was 16 short of a second century of the match, Suthar went wider, outside leg stump, fighting the ball and inviting the left-hander to manufacture a scoring shot. Dinusha tried to clip it, inside-edged the ball onto his pad and watched it balloon to leg gully.

Then came Prabath Jayasuriya. This time Suthar offered pace and drift—92.7kph, an in-drifting length delivery that appeared to give the left-hander enough line to defend from the back foot. But the ball gripped, turned away just enough to beat the outside edge and crashed into the off stump. Three balls, three different lengths at different speeds, all bearing the same result.

That is perhaps the most persuasive evidence yet that Suthar's value lies not merely in being a left-arm spinner, but in being a spinner who produce different problems with the same action. KL Rahul identified precisely this quality.

"It's the subtle variations from the same action from the same angle," he said, pointing out that Suthar can bowl slower or quicker without noticeably changing his arm speed. "Especially in Galle, with the wind blowing from one side and he used that drift really well, and from there the ball straightens or comes in."

That distinction matters enormously for an orthodox slow left-arm, since the same bowling action can create a leg-before as well as a caught-behind dismissal. The temptation with such bowling is to think in terms of stock deliver-



ies: bowl accurately, wait for the pitch to intervene and hope pressure eventually produces a mistake. Suthar appears to have a more sophisticated proposition. He can make a batter feel that nothing is happening, while constantly changing the terms of engagement.

The numbers after only two Tests are already striking: 17 wickets, two five-wicket hauls, a ten-wicket match haul and a strike rate of 27.2, while conceding just 2.49 runs an over.

These are excellent numbers but the manner of taking the 17 wickets provides a more compelling argument that Suthar possesses the ability to challenge several modes of dismissal from the same corridor.

Rahul's observation is instructive. "I think he's very consistent," he said. "From the same place he just keeps using subtle variations through the day. So the batsmen will also think if he's not moving then I'll have to do something. When you get a batter in that sort of mindset you're winning the contest."

There is another reason for optimism. Suthar hasn't arrived completely unprepared for Test cricket's demands. India's first-class structure has given him a bridge between Ranji Trophy cricket and international cricket through India A tours and exposure to conditions in Australia, Sri Lanka and England. Rahul believes that process matters.

The jump from domestic cricket to Test cricket is enormous, he said, but India's pathway allows players to understand their own games and the expectations of international cricket before receiving the Test cap. Suthar's early returns suggest that education has already taken root.

US teen Tan plots shock upset of contender Sen

INDIA-CAPE VERDE LIKELY ON OCT 6

Dhiman Sarkar

dhiman@htlive.com

KOLKATA: India are likely to play Cape Verde in Kolkata or Kochi on October 6. With the match against Brazil scheduled here on October 3 and two more away to New Zealand in November, 2026 could be the year India play four matches against teams from the last World Cup, an unprecedented event.

In other news, an AIFF official said Diamond Harbour FC have failed to meet Wednesday's 2pm deadline to pay approx ₹66 lakh as the second instalment of their participation fee for the Indian Super League. "It is possible that this season will have 13 teams," the official said.

Pragg qualifies for Grand Tour final

ST. LOUIS: Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa beat Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France to jump to joint lead alongside Wesley So after the eighth round of the Sinquefeld Cup. The Indian is now assured of a place in the Grand finale scheduled later this year.

Pakistan bundled out for 171 on Day 1

LONDON: Ollie Robinson and Josh Tongue took five wickets each as England made a strong start to the post-Bazball era by dismissing Pakistan for 171 in the first Test at Leeds. Robinson bagged 5/51 while Tongue took 5/46.

Sandip Sikdar

sandip.sikdar@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: On a day when the home crowd at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium arrived expecting a routine march into the last 16, India's leading men's singles hope Lakshya Sen fell for a 73-minute Round of 32 exit at the BWF World Championships here on Wednesday.

The 14th seed, who won bronze at this event in 2021, was stunned 19-21, 21-19, 21-17 by 18-year-old American sensation Garret Tan in a physical match that saw dives, falls, medical timeouts and a complete reversal of tactical momentum.

Sen, who came into the tournament seeking to replicate his previous podium exploits, started aggressively. Taking the opening game 21-19, the world



Lakshya Sen and Garret Tan (R) after the last point. SANCHIT KHANNA/HT

No.14 relied on fast front-court coverage and steep, angled half-smashes to keep the athletic American at bay.

But as Tan started using his

height to fire booming, downward smashes, neutralising Sen's net speed with heavy back-line clears, the script inverted.

Following the gruelling

decider, where Sen fought back from 11-4 down to bring the score to 17-16 before errors cost him the final stretch, the Indian required immediate medical attention for bruises sustained from multiple full-court dives before addressing the media.

"It was a very tough match, a hard-fought match. I gave my all, whatever I had in my tank. I was also exhausted physically in the third game," Sen said. "I will give a lot of credit to him, he played a solid game. I am a little disappointed, though I gave my all in the end it wasn't enough. He was just a better player today."

Addressing his tactical struggles through the contest, Sen said Tan's aggressive length kept him perpetually on the back foot.

"He was quite dominant. I was always playing cover-up. I had my chances, but he was taking

the points and I was playing under pressure a lot of times."

The mood in the opposite camp was one of jubilation mixed with awe. Tan, a southern California boy who splits his training between USA and Taiwan, played with a maturity beyond his age and ranking (world No.92). Sitting in his corner was an all-female support system featuring coach Paula Lynn and current shuttler Lauren Lam, who lost her women's doubles Round of 32 partnering Allison Lee, on Tuesday.

Lynn praised Tan as a "hard-working, God-fearing athlete". Asked about "lady luck", the all-female corner, Lynn quipped that every young player benefits from "a bit of motherly coach-

ing" and "big sister support" during high-stakes matches.

Mixed day for Indians

Former world champion PV Sindhu coasted into the pre-quarterfinals with a 21-16, 21-17 win over Canada's Zhang Wen Yu, setting up a clash against third seed Wang Zhi Yi of China.

Ayush Shetty, who ousted defending champion Shi Yu Qi on the opening day, dismantled Sri Lanka's Duminidu Abeywickrama 21-8, 21-10. In men's doubles, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty received a walkover into the Round of 16.

Unnati Hooda though squandered two match points against Michelle Li of Canada, eventually losing 11-21, 21-9, 23-21.

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA OFFICE OF THE ENGINEER-IN-CHIEF RURAL WORKS, ODISHA, BHUBANESWAR				25001/978/2627
Letter No. 29542, Dated. 17-8-26 Email i.d.: crew_bbsr@yahoo.com				
"e" Procurement Notice for road with bridge works in Odisha (Online-02 (Bridges) / 2026-27 dt. 17.08.2026)				
1. Name of the work	: Construction of road with Bridge work			
2. Total No. of works	: 03 (Three) nos			
3. Estimated cost	: Rs 1283.49 to Rs. 1731.04 lakh			
4. Class of contractor	: "A" Class & "Special" Class as applicable.			
5. Period of completion	: As mentioned in Column 7 of TCN.			
6. Other details	:			
Procurement Officer	Bid identification No.	No. of road works	Availability of tender online for bidding	
			From	To
Chief Engineer, Building & Bridges, Rural Works, Odisha, Bhubaneswar	Online-02/ 2026-27 (Bridges)	03 (Three) nos	29.08.2026 at 11.00 A.M	21.09.2026 Up to 5.00 P.M.
Other details can be seen in the bidding documents, which will be available in website www.tendersodisha.gov.in				
Chief Engineer, Buildings & Bridges Rural Works, Odisha, Bhubaneswar OIPR - 25001/25123/1/26-27/0012				

	OFFICE OF THE ENGINEER-IN-CHIEF (CIVIL), ODISHA		34001/658/2627
	NIRMAN SOUDHA, UNIT-V, BHUBANESWAR		
	E-mail ID:cebuildings_orissa@yahoo.co.in / cebuildings@rediffmail.com		
	Tel. -(0674)- 2391523		
INVITATIONS FOR BIDS (IFB)			
File No-B-II-(OLL&C)-19/2026		Lr. No. - 30121	Bhubaneswar, the 18th August, 2026
Invitation for Bids			
Bid Identification No. CE-Bldg-I-30/2026-27			
1.	The E.I.C. (Civil), (I/c) Chief Engineer, Buildings-I, Odisha, Bhubaneswar, on behalf of Governor of Odisha, invites percentage rate bids in double cover system in ONLINE MODE only, for the work, "Planning, Design, Construction, Restoration and external development of Biplabi Dharanidhara Sangrahalaya at Kusumita Village in Keonjhar District" as detailed below.		
2.	Nature of work	:	Building Work
3.	No. of work	:	01 No.
4.	Bid Cost.	:	Rs. 10,000/-
5.	Class of Contractor	:	'A' / Special
6.	Availability of Bid Documents in the website	:	From dt.28.08.2026 to 17.00 Hours of dt.11.09.2026.
7.	Date of Opening of Bid	:	Dt.17.09.2026 at 11:30 AM.
8.	The Bidders have to participate in ONLINE bidding only. Further details can be seen from the website: https://tendersodisha.gov.in Any addendum / corrigendum / cancellation of tender can also be seen in the said website only		
Engineer-in-Chief(Civil) (I/c) Chief Engineer, Buildings-I, Odisha OIPR - 34001/34171/1/26-27/0062			

MUMBAI METROPOLITAN REGION DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY (A Government of Maharashtra Undertaking)									
2nd floor, Engineering Division, Plot Nos. R-5, R-6 & R-12, Bandra-Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400 051. Tel. 022-65964165/4055, Fax: 65964179. Email : ajinkya.kenekar@mailmmrda.maharashtra.gov.in web: https://mmrda.maharashtra.gov.in									
e-Tender Notice									
Digitally signed & unconditional online B-1 tender are invited by MMRDA from registered & experienced agencies for following works.									
Sr. No.	Name of Work	Estimated Cost (In Rs.)	Cost of Blank Tender Form (Per Each)	Earnest Money Deposit (In Rs.)	Bid Document Download		Last Date of Online Submission	Contract Period	
					From Date/Time	To Date/Time			
1	Structural repairs to EI for building no.9 at HDL, Kiroli, Kurla Premier, Kurla (W).	4,63,29,894/- (Excluding GST)	2360/-	4,63,299/-				12 Months (Including Monsoon)	
2	Structural repairs to EI in LIG building, Chembur.	2,38,45,464/- (Excluding GST)	1180/-	2,38,455/-	20.08.2026 (12.00 Hrs)	02.09.2026 (12.00 Hrs)	02.09.2026 (12.00 Hrs)	06 Months (Including Monsoon)	
3	Providing repairs to mechanical ventilation system in LIG building, Chembur.	1,76,67,830/- (Excluding GST)	1180/-	1,76,678/-				06 Months (Including Monsoon)	
Note :- The e-tender can be downloaded from e-tender portal: " https://etendermmrda.maharashtra.gov.in " For any additional information & help for uploading & downloading the e-Tenders, please contact MMRDA's e-tendering service desk at the following ID: etendersupport@mailmmrda.maharashtra.gov.in and Phone No. 022-6596-7445									
Date : 20.08.2026 Place : Bandra (E), Mumbai No. : MMRDA/ED/Kurla/Chembur/2026									
								Sd/- Executive Engineer (Elect) Engineering Division	

Goals flow as India down Pak to enter second stage

Rutvik Mehta

rutvik.mehta@htlive.com

MUMBAI: India versus Pakistan in hockey may have ceased to be a rivalry, going strictly by the term's definition and the predictability of the eventual outcome. What it still does manage to often deliver, however, is goals. And a fair few of them.

Eight is what the Men's World Cup clash at the Wagener Hockey Stadium in Amstelveen, Netherlands, brought along on Wednesday. That goal volume was exactly the same as the last time the two neighbours met in the Pro League in June (7-1 India), and one better than before that (4-3 India).

Also better, for a change, was the competitiveness.

India won like they were expected to, and with it advanced to the next stage of this new-format World Cup. But in their 5-3 victory India did not run all over Pakistan, like they did in their last Pro League encounter, or at the last Asian Games where the 10-2 scoreline reflected the gulf between the two traditional hockey powerhouses.

It appeared to be headed that way even in this rare India-Pakistan contest in a World Cup, where the last time Pakistan beat India was four decades ago.

Setting the tone for a frenetic tussle with intensity and intent, the men in saffron were up 2-0 in 10 minutes and 3-0 in 20.

The men in white and green, finishing off a lot better than they began, though did not let it slip into one-way traffic territory, creating enough speedbumps for India to make it 4-2 at half-time and 5-3 at the end.

An extended fist bump along with a little jump and a loud "Cmon" was Harmanpreet Singh's way of celebrating their second victory in this World Cup that was more essential and emotional. It ensured that India, coming off the 4-2 defeat to England, progressed to the next round as the second-best team from Pool D.

The captain was again at the forefront of the team's set-piece returns, flicking and sweeping goals from two penalty corners



India players celebrate after scoring against Pakistan during their FIH World Cup Pool D match in Amstelveen.

(PC) in the 5th minute and 21st. Yet it was Abhishek's individual brilliance and craftsmanship leading to two quality field goals (11th, 24th) that was the standout, and that India would need more of going deeper into the tournament.

Hardik Singh got India's fifth goal through a penalty stroke in the 35th minute, after a period where Pakistan grew into the battle and got on the board through Hannan Shahid's field goal (22nd) and Sufyan Khan's PC (24th). Shahid kicked off the final quarter with another strike (46th) that threatened to take India down the path of the 4-3 Pro League game in which Pakistan hit two late goals. India held on here, despite going down to 10 men for the majority of the final five minutes.

Errors of such kind would be somewhat concerning for coach

Craig Fulton as they run into stronger opponents. As will India's control on the ball and defensive structure that met rocky waters after a smooth start.

"These games can go like that. We've got to do a better job of controlling that," Fulton said in his half-time assessment. "We need to be better on the ball, and stop the turnovers."

Turnovers weren't even in question in the first quarter, where India forayed into the circle in the first minute, took a shot at goal in the second, and bossed throughout the 15. A rocket reverse shot from Abhishek earned India their first PC, which Harmanpreet deposited to the bottom right corner in the retake.

The two men were at it again six minutes later.

A clever high ball from Har-

manpreet was taken down with aplomb inside the circle by Abhishek, who quickly directed it towards the Pakistan goal.

After the captain got his day's second — this time after a PC innovation, save, rebound and a pass got him to belatedly sweep the ball into goal instead of flick it right through — it was time for Abhishek's solo show again. Attacking from the left, the 27-year-old made the Pakistani defence dance to his tunes, dribbling, circling, swerving and tricking multiple white jerseys while engineering another delightful field goal.

Abhishek's superb display, to go with Harmanpreet (five goals in three games) already going better than his entire 2023 World Cup tally, were the biggest takeaways for India.

That the team stuttered in phases yet again, and let slip three goals, remains a critical area to improve for its semi-final ambitions.

Unbeaten women look to advance

AMSTELVEEN: Unbeaten and brimming with confidence after a strong start to their campaign, India will look to seal a place in the second round of the FIH Women's Hockey World Cup when they take on a desperate England in their final Pool D match here on Thursday.

A draw will be enough for India to progress as pool toppers. However, the team would prefer to secure its passage with another strong performance after holding world No.4 and Olympic silver medalists China to a 2-2 draw before thrashing lower-ranked South Africa 6-1.

PTI

Vivaan, Shohradova clinch rapid titles

MUMBAI: India and Turkmenistan shared the top honours in the Asian Junior Rapid Chess Championship 2026, as Vivaan Vishal of India and Shohradova Lala of Turkmenistan emerged champions in the Open and girls' sections respectively.

The Open championship witnessed a dramatic turnaround

on the final day, with halfway leaders, Akhilbay Imangali of Kazakhstan and Madhavendra Pratap Sharma of India, suffering crucial defeats in the concluding rounds.

Capitalising on the opportunity was Vivaan, who registered a hat-trick of victories in the final three rounds to clinch the title

outright with an impressive score of 6 points from 7 rounds.

In the girls' event, the battle for the title came down to a thrilling contest between Shohradova and Pratitee Bordoloi of India. Both players finished with identical scores of 6 points from 7 rounds. Shohradova edged ahead on tiebreaks.

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